

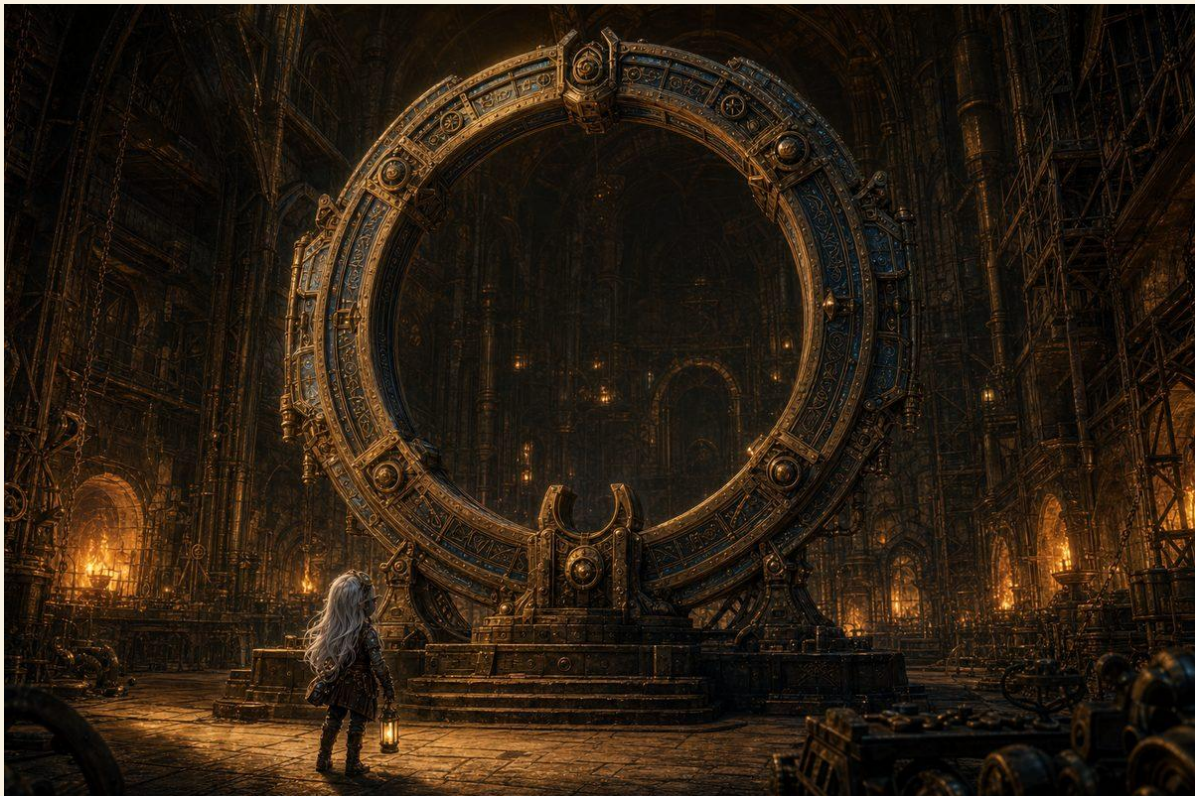


THE GUARDIANS OF ELARIA

SESSION 8

Underroot

An illustrated adventure. Read the gold boxes aloud; the purple boxes are for the DM.



The Rift Hall at midnight: ten years of Vane's life, finished, and nobody has dared switch it on.

Previously, on The Guardians of Elaria...

In the clockwork city of **Gearhaven** the heroes freed the **Grand Custodian**, the great machine that makes the city's heartbeat, from the corruption twisting it. The city's wounds knitted shut behind them, and they learned the rule that governs everything since: **a crack cannot be sealed from our side, but free a world's guardian and its cracks close on their own.**

Guildmaster Vane showed them his life's work, a ring of brass ten years in the building, waiting on the one thing it lacked: an anchor. The **Essence Sphere** is that anchor. Pikachu's spark spoke to them through Ursa's Mark, in dread-images rather than words, of a vast hunger and a herald-shadow, and of itself as *a key. To something.*

And then, because the ring would not be ready for a year, the three of them went their separate ways. **This session opens on the day they come back.**

► The heroes return at **level 7**. Hand out the new sheets during **The Handover**, so the fiction and the paperwork land in the same beat. Part One is read like a chapter; Part Two is played on the Underroot board.

Part One: The Year Apart

Four arrivals, three stories, and a door that has never been opened.

Seven Days Early

The Artificer's Guild never really sleeps, but at this hour it comes close. Down in the Underworks the furnaces are banked to a low orange mutter, and the great ring of the portal stands in the middle of the Rift Hall like something dreaming. The Rift Hall is the tall room at the head of the Underworks, galleried and railed the whole way around, and its high clerestory windows come out above the roofline, so that even down here you can look up and find a piece of the Gearhaven sky.

It is finished. After ten years of Guildmaster Vane's life it is finished, and it has been finished for eleven days, and nobody has dared to switch it on.

You have been here a week. You told yourself it was to check the anchor housing. It was really because you could not stand another night of waiting somewhere else.

► **Three things to land this week. Vane has aged:** ten years of work ended eleven days ago and he does not know what to do with his hands, so he is louder than usual and sleeping less, and he will not say he is frightened. **Lilly is the expert now**, and the guild artificers ask her opinion and mean it. And **the cradle does not quite fit**, because Vane built it from drawings of a sphere he had only had described to him; when she finally sets the real thing in on the sixth night the brass closes around it as though it were cut for it. Play that quiet. It is the first hint of what she learned.

The Professor



Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone arrives with three trunks and no help whatsoever, and Lickgloom rides the luggage.

He is exactly as you remember him and slightly worse: tall, silver haired, entirely certain, and delighted to be proven wrong about anything as long as he is the one doing the proving. He looks at the ring for a long moment, and then at the Sphere in its cradle, and then he says, to nobody in particular:

"Oh. That is much older than you think it is."

He says it the way other people say good morning.

Lickgloom remembers them. He stayed behind at Ravenstone Laboratory two years ago and has spent the time since licking a professor's equipment. He recognises the party instantly and is beside himself about it. Give this a beat: it is the only uncomplicated happy reunion in the whole session.

Dawn, and the Eastern Gate



He comes in with the dawn traffic, on foot, taller and quieter than he left.

He comes in with the dawn traffic, on foot, with road dust to his knees.

He is taller. That is the first thing. The second is that he is quiet in a way he never used to be, and he waits half a beat before he answers you, as though he is listening to something a half second behind your voice. There is a stone in his left hand that he turns over and over without seeming to know he is doing it.

He has been walking east for a year. He does not look like someone who found what he was looking for. He does not look like someone who failed, either.

Ten to Midnight

The bell over the Rift Hall doors has not rung all evening. It does not ring now either, because the goblin coming through them does not touch them.

He is on the rail above you before anybody thinks to look up. He is leaner, and there is a new sword across his back, dark and quiet, and when he drops down into the lamplight he lands without a sound, which he absolutely never used to do.

"I'm not late," says Stabby Sharpblade. "It's still today."



He has ten minutes in hand, and he has almost certainly been in Gearhaven since the afternoon.

► **The idol.** When Stabby swings his pack down, something inside knocks against the flagstones with a dull, wrong sound. It is the small carved idol that appeared in his bag after Wraithpine, which nobody has ever explained and no one saw put there. Here, forty feet from a portal that is not even lit, **it is cold enough to burn.** He has carried it a year and it has never done that. Do not explain it. Let it sit there.

The Year Apart: Three Stories

► Give each player the floor and read their chapter in full. This order builds best: Lilly's is the most hopeful, Stabby's is the loudest, and Ursa's changes the shape of the campaign, so it goes last.

Lilly: The Year of Questions



Deepforge Hollow, and a mother with flour on her hands.

She went home first. That surprised everyone, including Lilly. She put the Essence Sphere on her mother's kitchen table and said: tell me everything.

What followed was the least satisfying conversation of her life. Poots told her about the day she brought it home, about the long nights fitting the brass around it, about the sigil work along the equator that took eleven tries to get right. She talked like a craftsman describing a commission. And Lilly, who had grown up on her mother's stories, noticed the shape of the hole in this one: **Poots never once said where the thing inside the brass had come from.**

So she went looking. She earned her answers out of Master Sparkwick at Glimmerspire, and then she followed the trade roads and paid a dozen artificers in the only currency she had, which was work. A season with a clockmaker who could not cast a single spell and whose escapements humbled her. Six weeks with a woman who built hands for injured miners. Two more passes through Gearhaven with Vane shouting about tolerances. Her craft went from clever to formidable.



Then she took it to wizards, who ask what a thing is, and one of them fainted, and another wrote her four increasingly frantic letters, and none of them knew.

The answer was in the brass. On the forty-first time she opened the housing she stopped admiring her mother's sigils and looked *underneath* them, and found older marks on a surface that should have been the inside of her mother's shell and was instead the outside of something else.



The brass was Glimmerspire. The brass was her mother, eleven tries and all. The thing inside the brass was old.

Her mother did not make the Essence Sphere. Poots Glimmergear found it, understood it was worth protecting, and spent a year of her own life building it a house. And the thing Lilly worked out on a workshop floor a long way from home: **it is a gatherer.** It was built to pull in loose planar essence and hold it. It held Pikachu because Pikachu's spark was loose, and the Sphere does not know the difference between a scrap of stray fire and somebody's friend. You cannot pick a gatherer's lock. You can only give it something to gather.

So she stopped building at it and started listening to it.

► **What she brings back.** *Aether Channeler*: she can draw the **Aether Ward** out of the Sphere, 2d8 + 5 temporary hit points to herself and every friend within 30 feet, twice per short rest. The five great discharges sleep until each plane's Mote comes home. **Her power now grows by going out**, which is the whole point. Also *Flash of Genius*: +5 to a failed check or save for her or any friend within 30 feet, five times a day.

Stabby: The Year He Went Back

Every clan has one child who is a problem, and the Bloodfang had Stabby. He could not do any of it. Goblin children learn the clan's arts from the time they can stand, and the arts simply did not take with him. Every stance slid off. He was not lazy and he was not stupid. He was *unteachable*, in a clan that had exactly one measure of a person's worth, and by the time he was five everyone had quietly agreed what he was going to be. So he became the joke instead. If they were going to laugh anyway, he would decide what they laughed at.

Then **Skitch** came. The young Bloodfang courier the party pulled half-dead out of the machinery under Gearhaven had been sent a very long way to find the only Bloodfang anyone could name who had gone out into the world and come back alive from anything. Stabby laughed at him, because the clan asking for him was the clan that had spent his whole childhood explaining he was not worth teaching. Then he stopped laughing, packed in about four minutes, and went.

Bloodthorn Hollow was dying, and the blight took the strongest first. The biggest hunter, then the second biggest, then down the list. The Bloodfang had one law, which was that the biggest goblin wins, and something in the woods was eating them in order. By the time Stabby walked back in, the clan was mostly the small ones. The overlooked ones. He knew every single one of them. He had been the smallest of them once.

He saved them the way he does everything, fast and loud and extremely well: eleven weeks of hunting, the whole Hollow moved twice over furious objection, traps a cleverer person would not have thought of. By the end of summer the Bloodfang were not dying anymore. **But he had not fixed it. He had only outrun it.** Candyfang went through the corrupted things the way a knife goes through smoke.

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father was the Fourth. The fourth leader the Bloodfang ever named, and by every account the of them. Nine years ago something came out of the deep woods, and the Fourth went to it alone, and he did not kill it, because it was not the kind of that can be killed. **He sealed it.** only vessel to hand that night was newborn son, and it cost him his do it. clan is named Bloodfang for that thing. Not for their own teeth. **Red Fang** is older than the Hollow.

And that is why the arts never took. There was something enormous asleep behind Stabby's ribs, pushing back against every form they poured into him. **He was never unteachable. He was occupied.**

The sect on the mountain are frog-folk, enormous with age, and they cared about exactly one thing and tested it on the first morning. They asked him to be **still**. Not to sit quietly, which he could have faked: still, entirely, from the inside, in the moment before violence.

He failed for eleven weeks. He nearly left twice. And then in the third month, in the dark, he heard Master Kaelon Windstep say the thing he had said years ago that Stabby had never once managed to do: *when the whole world is screaming, little storm, get still*.

He had always heard it as an instruction to calm down. It was not. It was smaller and far more useful. **Be still for one second, at the one moment that matters.** One second, Stabby could do.



A Nichirin blade is a graduation, not a gift. He worked the bellows for eight days of it.



He came home in deep winter and burned the thing out of the ground, root and all, exactly as he had promised.

The Bloodfang had watched their biggest and best taken one after another for two years, and the thing that finally walked out of the twisted woods with the blight dead behind it was **the runt**. The clan joke. The one they had all quietly agreed was not worth teaching. There is not a goblin in the Hollow who will hear a word against him now.



What made him something else was teaching it. The Vigil gave him the basics; his clan gave him the rest.

► They offered him his father's seat and **he said not yet**, and Nokk was the only one who noticed he did not say never. He gave them Candyfang as the clan's heirloom, and by their new law the heirloom is carried by whoever the clan would follow, which is why it is still on his belt. It is not his anymore. It is theirs, and he is only wearing it.

Ursa: The Road East

The other two went home. Ursa went the other way.

"You are eight," Selarin said. "I know how old I am," said Ursa. On the ninth day the old man handed over his father's field notes without a word, and then said one thing, which Ursa has repeated to nobody: *your father read the sky better than any of us. It did not save him. Read the ground too.*

The notes are the working papers of a man in the middle of a thought: sky charts with dates, the same constellation drawn eleven times over eleven months with one point of light getting fainter each time, and one word underlined twice and never explained. **Betelgeuse**. The first star to go out.

The notes stop in the middle of a page. Not at the end of a thought. In the middle of one.





The Skyless Country: ordinary land under a sky that never breaks. For a druid who navigates by constellations, a blindfold.

He went east on foot and **alone**, because Ghostbloom stayed at the Guild and where he was going had no roads. Eleven months of walking. And when the maps ran out he came into a country where the cloud never breaks, and he lost eleven days in there, and he will not talk about the eleven days.

What saved him was that his father had been there first. **A road of cairns**, each placed exactly at the edge of sight of the last, so a person could cross the blind land one stone at a time. Ash built it going out. Ursa walked it going in, and **repaired eleven of them on the way**, because there was no reason to assume he would be the last person to need the road.



The old shrine, far east beyond the maps. A camp in the condition of a place somebody meant to come back to.

He did not find his father. He found the camp his father made: a firepit long cold, a shelter of bent living branches still holding, split wood stacked dry and ready, a tin cup. Nothing packed. Nothing buried. **Nobody had said goodbye to this place.**

And he found out how long ago by doing exactly what Selarin told him. The shelter was still alive and still growing, and the wood had closed over the bindings by an amount a druid can read like a page.

Not fifteen years. **Three.**

Under the flat rock, wrapped in oilcloth against the weather, was a river stone carved with Elaria's seven-pointed star. **Half of it.** The line stops mid-stroke, the way a pen stops when somebody says your name. It is his father's hand. When Ursa closed his fingers around it the stone was warm, and it has been warm ever since.





On the eighth night the cloud broke, and the standing stones lit from the inside.

Elaria showed him three things.

The first was his father **walking**, deliberately, toward a light that was going out. Ursa has carried a small ugly question since he was old enough to understand the word *disappeared*: did my father choose to leave me? The answer is yes, and the reason is the best reason there has ever been. **Ash Catchum went east to save the stars.**

The second was a wall at the bottom of everything, and behind it a hunger with patience, pressing. He knew the name from the Circle's old verses before the vision gave it to him. **Maldrith.**

The third was a shadow that walks for her, on a high place with the sky dying behind it, putting out a light as calmly as a person pinching a candle. And the vision gave that one a name too, the way you hand somebody a weapon. **Nyxthid.**

► **This is the first time the name Nyxthid is spoken in this campaign.** Ursa has just sworn to hunt his own father and will spend four sessions doing it. Elaria did not lie to him: every single thing she showed him is true. She simply did not show him that the man walking east and the shadow in black are the same person. **Keep the figure featureless.** No face, no build, nothing that can be matched later. If a player asks what it looked like, it looked like a hole in the shape of a person.

The Handover



A cloth on the bench for each of them, which is a very Lilly way of doing things.

Lilly has been awake since four. There is a cloth on the bench for each of you, and a fourth at the end for Puff, the small clay homunculus she built and woke up herself, who is already sitting beside hers with her hands folded. Lilly has clearly rehearsed this speech, and she gets about six words into it before she gives up and just starts handing things over.

► **Hand out the new character sheets here**, so the fiction and the paperwork happen in the same beat. Six magic items land on three players at once and none of them work like a sword, so teach the traps now, in a quiet room, rather than on the far side of the ring.

WHAT LILLY BUILT DURING THE YEAR

Sorted by whose cloth it is sitting on

Wraps of Unarmed Power +2 (Stabby). No attunement, nothing to activate. +2 to hit and damage on every punch and kick, and they may deal Force. **The trap:** they do nothing at all for the katana.

Wand of the War Mage +2 (Ursa). While he is **holding** it, every spell attack gains +2 and he ignores Half Cover. Starry Wisp, his Guiding Bolts and the star-arrow all go to +10. **The trap:** it does not touch his save DC.

Wand of Web (Lilly). 7 charges, 1 to cast Web. **The trap:** it casts at its own **DC 13**, not her DC 16.

Ring of Spell Storing (Puff). Holds 5 levels of spells and casts them at the original caster's DC and slot. **The trap:** it arrives **EMPTY** and does nothing until somebody casts into it.

Wand of Magic Missiles (Puff). 1 charge for three darts that never miss, 1d4+1 force each, 120 ft. Up to 3 charges for five darts.

Pipes of Haunting (Puff). 3 charges. Magic action: every creature she chooses within 30 ft. makes a DC 15 Wisdom save or is Frightened for a minute.

► **Puff has one action**, so she uses only one of her three items per turn. And **wands recharge at dawn, not on a rest**, which matters on the far side of a portal where nobody knows how time runs.

The Briefing



Aelwyn talks, Vane interrupts, and Lickgloom licks something he should not.

One. The rifts are not doors somebody opened; they are tears, and everything strange the party has fought for two years came through one. **Two.** You cannot sew a tear from this side: you go to the other side and bring back the plane's **Mote**, the piece of its heart caught here. **Three.** The Sphere is the anchor and the way home, and **if it is lost over there, they do not come back.** Say that once, plainly, and never repeat it. **Four.** Every Mote returned wakes a little more of the Sphere. **Five.** Something living may come back with them, and Aelwyn is carefully vague, because he is guessing.

"I want you to understand that I am not sending you somewhere dangerous," Aelwyn says. "I am sending you somewhere *indifferent*. A plane is not hostile to you any more than a mountain is hostile to you. It simply does not care whether you can breathe there. Everything that hurts you on the other side will hurt you the way weather does."

Vane snorts. "That is a terrible speech."

"It is an honest one."

The Lesson: Underroot, and the Thing That Lives There



He does this properly, with a chalkboard and far too much enthusiasm.

"Earth," says the professor, "is not a cave. I want that out of your heads immediately. You are not going underground. You are going to a place that is *made* of ground, all the way through, in every direction, forever."

"It is called Underroot. There is no sun there and it has never needed one. There are roots down there the size of cathedrals, and they are alive, and they are older than your species. The soil breathes, slowly, about once a minute. And nothing there is in a hurry, which will be the strangest part for you three."

► **Three facts the players need for Part Two.** It is **slow, not empty**: a rockfall there is a shrug. There is **no sky, so Ursa cannot navigate**, and his year of star-reading buys him nothing; what works is reading the ground, exactly as Selarin told him. And it is **indifferent, not hostile**.

"Every world keeps something. Not a king and not a god. A *guardian*: one creature, very old, that is somehow the shape of that world's health. When Gearhaven was sick you found the Grand Custodian at the heart of it, twisted almost past recognition, and when you freed it the whole city knitted shut behind you. Do you remember?"

He taps the board. "You did not do that by being clever. You did it by being *kind* to something that was hurting. I would like you to notice that, because you are about to do it again, and the thing you do it to this time is roughly the size of a hill."

"What if it fights us?" says Stabby, delighted.

"Then I would prefer you not *lose*."

► The Guardian of Underroot is **Groudon**. Aelwyn does not know its name and neither should the party: let them meet it as a shape in the dark and a sound in their teeth before it is ever a stat block.

The Threshold

► Last beats, in this order. **Ursa looks up** and sees that Antares is dimming, and says nothing; do not spend that, it pays off at the end of the night. **The idol goes cold** again in Stabby's pack, hard enough that he notices. **Lilly sets the Sphere in the cradle** and it fits like it was cut for it. And **Vane does not make a speech**: he had ten years to write one, and what he actually does is put a hand on Lilly's shoulder for a second and then go and stand at the lever.

The ring does not roar. That is the surprising part.

The Sphere settles into the cradle with a small brass click, and the air inside the circle simply stops being air. What is on the other side is a red-brown dark, and warmth, and a smell like a garden turned over after rain, and a sound so low that you feel it in your teeth rather than hear it.

Somewhere on the far side of that opening, something the size of a hill breathes in.

Ghostbloom goes first, because of course she does.

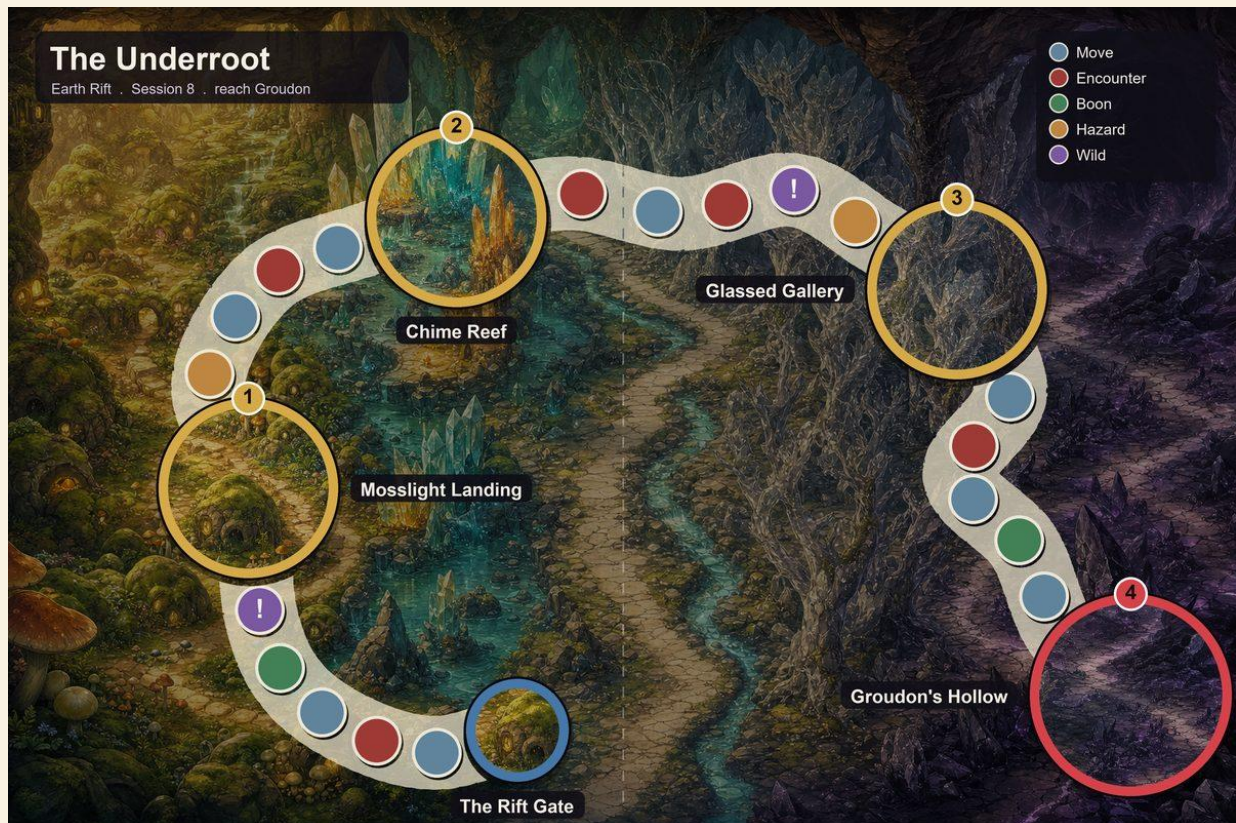


The last picture before everything changes.

Part Two: Underroot

They stepped through a brass ring in a workshop in Gearhaven and came out the other side standing on something warm that was breathing.

How the Board Works



The Underroot board: twenty-two dots between the gate and the Hollow, and four fixed stops that do not move.

- **One token, everybody's hands.** The party moves as a single token. On their turn a player rolls **1d6** and moves that many spaces, and whoever holds the token rotates on every roll, so every player gets to move it. They land on a colour and it resolves at once.
- **The die they moved with resolves the dot.** Each colour has two outcomes, and even or odd picks which one happens: no table to look up, no second roll, no pause. Slate blue is plain movement and does nothing on either result. All eight outcomes are written out in full in *The Road Between*.
- **The four numbered locations are not dots.** They are fixed story stops. The token halts at each one no matter how much movement is left, the beat plays out, and movement resumes on the next turn. **The Rift Gate is the arrival and has no fight.**
- **They came here to fight.** Nothing in this session can be talked down, waited out, or avoided. Levers and objectives exist to turn a grinding fight into a satisfying one, never to skip it, and finding one is the reward.
- **SHORT REST, immediately after the reef.** Call it out loud so nobody misses it: Hit Dice spent, Stabby's Focus back, Ursa's Wild Shape back, Lilly's Aether Ward back. Fight 3 assumes they took it.
- **A note on the numbers.** Fights 2 and 3 sit deliberately above a "deadly" budget on paper, and both have a lever that collapses them: **thunder stuns a Chimestone and doubles all damage against it**, and **tending the roots strips the Weeper's regeneration**. A party that finds the lever

wins comfortably. A party that ignores it is in a real fight. That gap is the fun, so do not soften either one before the players have had their chance to be clever.

The Road Between

Underroot is not empty between the landings, and the dark between them has its own weather.

The ground stays warm the whole way, and it goes on breathing under your boots, slow as something enormous asleep. There is no sky to measure your progress against, so the only way to know you are moving is the moss light going out behind you, patch by patch, as you leave it.

Twice, something out in the dark keeps pace with you for a while. It is big enough to hear. It never arrives.

► **How a dot resolves.** Read the die they moved with. **Garnet** is an Encounter (even: Thumpaw; odd: the Gleamoth). **Moss** is a Boon (even: the Deepwater Spring; odd: the Shortcut). **Ochre** is a Hazard (even: Sinkloam; odd: the Ceiling Lets Go). **Amethyst** is Wild (even: the Reef Answers; odd: the Guardian's Dream). Slate blue is simply movement: nothing happens, keep going.



Thumpaw, the boulder that minds being prodded.



The Gleamoth, hungry for the warmest thing in the tunnel.

► **Garnet dots are small pressure, and that is all they are.** Two or three weak things that cost a little resource and no more. Never let a dot roll swell into a fifth big fight: the four scripted encounters are the session, and the dots are texture between them. Thumpaw and the Gleamoth appear nowhere else in Underroot, which is exactly what makes a garnet dot feel like luck instead of filler. Pace check: there are 22 dots between the gate and the Hollow, so if the evening is running long, hand-wave the dots between locations 3 and 4 and go straight to Groudou.

Thumpaw

A shape unfolds out of what you took for a boulder. It is the size of a cart horse, round and shaggy with matted brown moss growing over stone-grey hide, and it has hands like shovels.

It looks at you with small patient eyes and does not move, because you are standing in the tunnel it was going to use.

► **Garnet dot, even. One Thumpaw.** It will not move, it is directly in the way, and when somebody inevitably prods it, it swings. This is a straight brawl and that is the point: **76 hit points**, two big slams a turn, no gimmick and no puzzle. Sometimes a table simply wants to hit something large until it stops, and this is that. It never pursues and it never finishes a downed hero; it is grumpy, not evil. If the party genuinely tries to befriend it rather than fight it, **DC 15 Animal Handling**, with advantage from Ursa's Mark of Handling, will move it aside. Do not offer that. Let them think of it.

The Gleamoth

The lights come round the corner before the sound does: forty pale green sparks drifting like blown seeds. They are moths, each the size of a hand, and every one of them is glowing, and they want the warmest thing in the tunnel, which is you.

► **Garnet dot, odd. Three Gleamoth Swarms**, not corrupted, just hungry for heat. They **blind and smother** rather than deal much damage, and they go for whoever is carrying light. **Fire and thunder scatter them fast**, so anything that hits an area is worth double here. The real cost is the Sphere: they are drawn to it hardest, which puts the swarm on Lilly for the whole fight and makes the rest of the party come to her.

The Deepwater Spring

A crack in the wall, and inside it a pool so still and so clear that the pale stones forty feet down look close enough to lift out. Nothing feeds it. Nothing drains it. And yet the surface keeps turning over, slow and patient, the way water moves when something a long way underneath it is still working. It is very cold, and it tastes like the air after lightning, and by the time you have all drunk, the ache has gone out of your legs and none of you can say when it left.



► **Moss dot, even.** Everyone regains **1 Hit Die** and clears **one level of exhaustion**. Ghostbloom glows brighter for an hour and is insufferable about it.

The Shortcut

Something small and yellow-brown is waiting for you on a mound in the middle of the path, up on its back legs, and it does not run when your light finds it. It looks at you. Then it looks, very deliberately, at the blank wall on its left. Then back at you, and it keeps doing that until somebody understands. Then it drops and digs, and the packed earth goes soft in front of its claws like water, and the tunnel it opens runs straight and level and exactly the way you were trying to go. It is gone before any of you reach the far end. All it leaves behind is a scuffed patch of loose soil where it stood, and the distinct feeling of having been done a favour.



► **Moss dot, odd. Advance the token 3 spaces free.** If the party was unkind to the Sandshrew at Mosslight Landing, it watches them take the long way round instead, and that should sting.

Sinkloam

The floor stops being floor. There is no sound and no warning: one step is packed earth and the next is warm wet loam that takes your boot, then your shin, then your knee, and goes on politely taking. It is worst for the smallest of you: the loam does not care how clever anyone is, and whoever goes in deepest is suddenly fighting to keep their arms above the surface while the ground drinks the rest of them with terrible, unhurried patience.



► **Ochre dot, even.** Everyone makes a **DC 13 Strength save** or is **restrained**, spending an action to pull free. Heavy armour has disadvantage on the save. If Lilly goes under, she holds the Sphere over her head with both hands the entire time, and somebody has to go back for her.

The Ceiling Lets Go

You feel it before you hear it: a low grinding roll somewhere far above, the sound a mountain would make turning over in its sleep. Then dust comes down in fine threads. Then the threads become gravel. You have exactly long enough to look up and understand what is about to happen, and nowhere near long enough to be somewhere else, and then the ceiling of the world lets go.



When the roar stops and the air clears enough to breathe, the passage you came in by is not there. In its place is a wall of new stone, still warm, still shifting and settling against itself, and above you Underroot has already gone quiet again, as though it had shrugged in its sleep and thought nothing of it.

► **Ochre dot, odd.** **DC 14 Dexterity save, 2d10 bludgeoning** on a failure and half as much on a success. The passage behind them is now blocked, which matters a great deal if anyone was planning to run.

The Reef Answers

Somewhere far off, a single crystal note. Then another underneath it, and another, until the whole tunnel is ringing in a slow enormous chord you can feel in your ribs, and the moss on the walls lights up in time with it.



► **Amethyst dot, even.** Everyone gains **2d8 temporary hit points**, and Ghostbloom sings back, badly, at the top of her voice. **This is a good place for the short rest** if the party has not taken it yet.

The Guardian's Dream

For half a second the three of you see the same thing, and Ghostbloom sees it too, and none of you asked for it.

An empty sea under an empty sky, going on forever. And something walking through it, huge and slow and patient, and where it walks the water shoulders aside and dry land comes up behind it, steaming, new.

Then it is gone and you are standing in a tunnel again.



The Guardian's Dream: an empty sea, and the thing that walked through it making land.

► **Amethyst dot, odd. No mechanical effect.** They have just watched Groudon remember his own job, and they will not understand what they saw until they are standing in front of him. Ursa may **regain one spent Omen Dream**, because something has just spoken to him and he does not know what.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ The Living Country

The sky-readers teach that a plane is not a place but a creature: one living thing wearing a country for a body, with weather for moods and seasons for a pulse. Walk gently, the Circle says, for every step in another world is a step on somebody. The old verses go further still: each world keeps one guardian, very old, that is somehow the shape of that world's health, and to free a guardian is to heal the country it carries.

The Descent

Four stops between the ring and the Guardian: a doorway, a village of moss, a reef that sings, and a wound that will not stop spreading.

The Rift Gate: The First Breath



The other side of the ring: one root like a cathedral ceiling, and no sky ever again.

You expected a cave.

What you are standing in is a root. One root, arching over you like the ceiling of a cathedral, running away into the dark in both directions further than your light reaches. The ground under your boots is warm, and soft, and it is breathing: a slow swell and settle, about once every minute, so gentle you would miss it if you were not standing still.

There is no sky. There is no sun. There is light, though, a low green-gold glow coming off the moss in patches, enough to see by, and the smell you caught through the ring is everywhere now: turned earth after rain, warm, with no other air behind it.

Behind you the ring hangs in the air, a bright coin of Gearhaven lamplight, and Vane's shape is standing in it with his arms folded, getting smaller.

► **Four beats to land here, one per hero and one for Ghostbloom. The Sphere is warm** in Lilly's hands, and it is *pulling*: she can feel it gathering, it has never done that before, and it does not stop for the rest of the session. **Ursa cannot navigate**, and say that to his player directly: no sky, no stars, and a year of star-reading buys him nothing. What does work is what Selarin told him, reading the ground, so give him **advantage on Survival** down here for root growth and soil. **Stabby's idol is cold**, colder than it was in the Rift Hall; he will keep checking it all session and it will keep getting worse. **Ghostbloom is delighted**, because she is a plant-spirit standing inside a plane made of growing things, and she has never been so happy. Let her chime read as joy all session, right up until the Hollow.

► **No encounter here.** They get exactly one safe scene to be amazed. Do not spend it.

1. Mosslight Landing: The Friendly Face



Mosslight Landing, the friendliest place in an unfriendly world.

The walk from the ring is the first walking any of you have ever done in another world, and it is not like walking anywhere else. The ground gives a little under each step, warm as the flank of something sleeping, and the moss lights up ahead of you and dims behind, so the country seems to open a road for you one patch at a time and quietly put it away once you have used it. Ghostbloom rides at head height with every petal spread, chiming to herself. Nothing hurries you. Nothing follows. It takes about an hour for that to stop feeling like mercy and start feeling like being noticed by something too big to be interested yet.

Then the root opens into a hollow the size of a village, and it is beautiful. Round mossy mounds swell out of the floor with little round doors of packed earth, though nobody built them and nobody lives in them: that is simply the shape moss grows in here. Threads of pale gold light drift up from the ground like slow sparks going the wrong way.

Something is watching you from the top of the nearest mound. It is about the size of a badger, armoured in overlapping plates of yellow-brown hide, with small dark eyes and enormous digging claws, and it is absolutely rigid with the effort of not being seen.

It is very bad at this. It is holding so still that it is trembling slightly with the effort, one claw still buried in the mound mid-dig at an angle nothing would choose to stand at, and when Stabby waves at it, it does not wave back, because rocks do not wave. It has decided that it is a rock. It is going to be a rock until this crisis passes, and it commits to the performance with a dignity that would break your heart if it were not so funny.

And here is the strange part: none of you reach for a weapon. It is not corrupted. You are all certain of that at once, without knowing why you are certain. It is just small, and you are new, and it got here first.

► **This is the Sandshrew**, and unless a moss dot sends it back to dig them a shortcut, this is the only time they meet it in the flesh before the homecoming. **It cannot be caught, tamed, or bagged.** It watches them. If they are kind to it or feed it, it follows at a distance for the rest of the run and is present at the end. If they are aggressive, it vanishes and joins them at the homecoming anyway, which will feel like a gift they did not earn. **Ursa's Mark of Handling works on it**, and that should be the moment his player realises the plane's wildlife is not the enemy.

You could spend an hour in this place, and you nearly do. The mounds are warm to lean against. The gold threads rise slowly enough to pick one and watch it all the way up into the dark. It is the first place since the ring that has felt less like a country and more like a welcome.

It is Ghostbloom who notices. Her chime changes in the middle of a note, the way a voice changes when it sees something over your shoulder, and she goes very still in the air, pointing with her whole body at the far side of the hollow.

The pretty part of Underroot has a wound in it. On the far mounds the moss is grey and wet and wrong, and standing in it, swaying, are six little flower-creatures.

They were lovely a month ago. You can still see it: round soft bodies, stubby arms, big round flower-caps that used to be gold. The caps are grey now, and slack, and they leak. When they notice you they all turn at once, and their faces are still smiling, because their faces cannot do anything else.

► **Let the players choose the moment.** The Rotblooms do not charge. They come on at a sway, slow as weather, leaking as they walk, and the grey spreads a hand's width behind them wherever they linger. Give the table a round of looking: some heroes will strike at once, some will try to talk to the smiling faces, and somebody may work out before a single swing that the flowers are not attacking, they are *spreading*. None of it changes what has to happen; this cannot be talked down, and left alone the grey takes the whole landing. But the party should walk into their first fight in Underroot knowing the enemy is the grey, never the flower wearing it. **The moment anyone engages, the instant the first cap is struck, read:**

Then the moss itself comes apart. The instant the first cap is struck, the ground boils: tiny six-legged things, one enormous eye each, pouring out of the mounds in a wave and swarming up your boots.

And Ghostbloom makes a sound you have never heard her make. She knows what these are. They are almost the same as her.





Fight 1: the landing defends itself, and Stabby learns what his year was for.

► **This fight exists to hand Stabby the session.** Rotblooms re-bloom every round, and ordinary steel keeps handing back ground it already won: leave one standing and part of that cap has swelled shut again before its next turn, so a good round of hits can end with the same six flowers swaying at them. **Cleansing Edge is the answer, and it is the only one the party has.** Let them flail for a round, let Lilly and Ursa watch pieces of their damage close up again, then let Stabby ignite, cut one, and have it *stay* cut. Say the reason out loud when it lands: he spent a year on a mountain learning to burn corruption out of the ground, and this is the first time anyone else has seen it work. His player has been carrying that backstory alone since the reading, so give him the beat.

► **The Mossmites keep everyone honest.** Six of them, fast and cheap, swarming boots and climbing packs while the real problem re-blooms behind them. Spore Puff means the whole party is rolling saves, Puff and Ghostbloom are in the mix, and everybody gets three or four rounds of swinging. Nobody stands still and nobody is bored while they wait for the lever to reveal itself.

► **The tell, for anyone watching closely:** the Rotblooms do not attack the Sandshrew and it does not run from them. It is hiding from the *party*. Corruption does not eat its own.

► **The first time a Rotbloom goes down and stays down, read:**

The grey goes first. It drains out of the cap the way muddy water wrings out of cloth, down and away into the soil, and the soil takes it and holds it, because that is what soil is for. And for one held breath the little creature is the colour it used to be: round and soft and gold, the loveliest thing on the landing, smiling because it wants to.

Then it sighs, one long easy breath like a child finally put to bed, and folds down into the moss, and where it lay the grey does not come back.

It is over faster than it felt. The last of the mites pour back into their mounds like water finding its level, and the landing goes quiet, and then, patch by patch, the ground where the grey was cut away begins to light again: one faint thread of gold, then a slow scatter of them, rising past your faces the wrong way, exactly as before.

The Sandshrew is back on its mound, at a careful distance, up on its hind legs. It is not pretending to be a rock anymore. It watched all of it, and it is watching you now the way you would watch somebody who just did a thing you did not know could be done. Ghostbloom says nothing at all, which from Ghostbloom is a great deal. She settles on Ursa's shoulder and stays there, ringing very softly, the same note the little flower sighed on. The road out of the hollow runs deeper and downward. The air coming up it is warmer than the air behind you, and somewhere a long way down, very faintly, something rings.

2. Chime Reef: The Beautiful Trap



The Chime Reef: gorgeous, ringing, and sharp enough to shave with.

The road out of the Landing runs uphill, and Underroot changes as you climb. The moss thins first, its green-gold light failing patch by patch until your own lamps are doing most of the work. Then the soil changes under it: drier, firmer, with a fine glitter worked all through it, and when Lilly stops and lifts a pinch to the light she finds tiny broken chips of crystal, blue and gold, more of them with every hundred feet, as though somewhere ahead something enormous were shedding.

Then comes the sound, except it is not a sound yet. It is a pressure, low and sweet, somewhere underneath hearing, rising out of the ground through the soles of your boots, and it grows with every step until you are leaning into it the way you lean into warmth.

The tunnel opens and you all stop at once, because the sound arrives before the sight does. Crystals. Thousands of them, growing up out of a shallow black pool in spires and fans and thickets, blue and gold and green, some of them taller than Vane's workshop. And the whole reef is *ringing*, very quietly, a slow shifting chord you feel in your back teeth. When the ground breathes, the note changes.

Ghostbloom lifts off Ursa's shoulder and hangs in the middle of all that ringing with every petal spread. She is a spirit made of chime, and she has never once heard anything answer

her. She rings, one small clear note out into the crystal, and the whole reef rings it back. Ursa, without deciding to, has taken his hand off his staff.

► **Three beats before the boulders stand up. Loud carries:** anything loud makes the crystals ring louder, and a big enough noise brings a spire down, so reward the player who works that out and uses it. **Lilly can read the growth pattern** with an Arcana check: the crystals are growing *toward* something deeper in, the way plants grow toward light, and the whole reef is leaning on whatever that is. (It is Groudon.) **And there is a quiet gift here.** If anyone spends a turn simply listening, Elaria's presence is faintly in the chord; Ursa's player may notice it is the same seven-note shape as the Havenmoor bells.

The reef has been answering you the whole way in, and none of you noticed, because the answers were beautiful.

Every footfall comes back off the crystal, tiny and bright. Lilly's pack clinks and a spire clinks back. Somebody laughs and the reef hums the shape of it half a second behind. And the deeper you go, the more of the chord leans toward you, note after note bending in your direction, until the truth of it lands all at once: you are the loudest, warmest, fastest-moving thing this reef has ever held, and you have been ringing its doorbell with every single step. The chord drops. It goes low, and flat, and wide awake. The moss light dims in one slow pulse, and out in the pool the ripples stop.

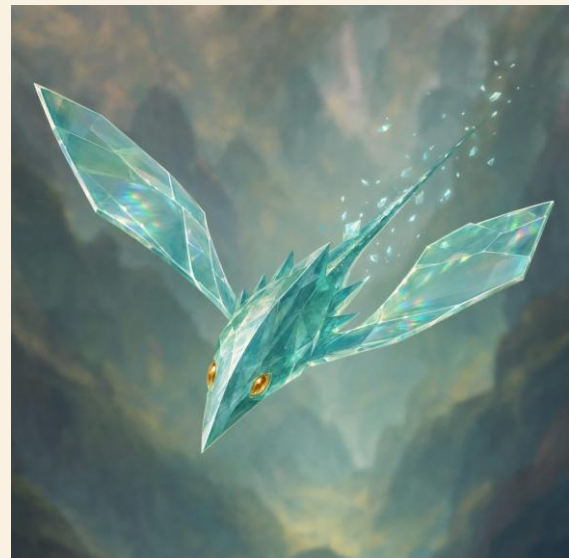
Three boulders in the shallows unfold legs and stand up.

They are squat and heavy and armoured in deep blue-black rock, with blunt jaws and small bright amber eyes, and jagged orange crystals growing out of their backs and shoulders like a struck chord frozen in place. Nothing about them is rotten or grey or wrong. They are simply enormous, and they are between you and the deep.

► **These are not corrupted.** The Chimestones are the reef's immune system, and the party is loud and warm and came in through a hole. That does not make them talkable: the reef has already decided. Play them as weather with legs.



And then the air is full of wings. Pale crystal darts the size of hawks drop out of the spires, bank once, and come down at you fast enough to whistle.





Fight 2: thunder in the reef. Find the lever and the wall becomes a bell.

► **This is a real fight and they are tough.** AC 16, they hit hard, and they resonate: every round the whole reef rings louder and everybody's ears hurt. The Shardwings are the reason nobody gets to stand still, diving in, spitting shards from sixty feet, and refusing to be pinned down.

► **The clever play does not end the fight, it wins it.** Thunder damage makes a Chimestone ring itself apart: any thunder damage **stuns it until the end of its next turn**, and it takes **double damage** from every source while stunned. Lilly's Thunderwave and Shatter, Stabby's Nichirin against the crystal, and Ursa's Thunderwave all turn one of these from a wall into a free kill, and the Shardwings are **vulnerable to thunder** as well, so the same lever works on the whole encounter.

► **The first time thunder damage lands on a Chimestone, read the following.** It is the turning point of the fight, and the whole table should hear it arrive.

The boom goes into the creature and does not come back out.

For one heartbeat the Chimestone stands perfectly still. Then it begins to ring itself apart from the inside: the orange crystals along its back shiver into a blur, its own deep note climbing, cracking, splintering into wild harmonics, and the creature locks up mid-stride, stunned rigid by the one sound its armour cannot keep out, which is its own.

And the reef takes up the note. Every spire, every fan, every thicket from the shallows to the dark edge of your light picks up the same stunned chord and sings it, the whole cavern ringing with the sound of the fight turning, and every one of you can hear that it has.

► **The reef itself is a weapon too.** Anyone can spend an action to strike a big spire (DC 13 Athletics): the note rolls out and every Chimestone within **30 ft.** must make a **DC 14 Constitution save** or be stunned as above. Let them bring the roof down on the last one if they earn it. **The trade-off that keeps it honest:** the ringing hurts the party too, so anyone who uses the spire trick takes **1d6 thunder** themselves. Nobody minds.

► **If a player strikes a spire and brings it down, read the following**, because they have just turned the terrain into a bell and they should feel it.

The spire goes over like a felled tree made of glass, and it does not crash. It **tolls**. One impossible note rolls out across the pool in a ring you can watch, bending the black water flat as it goes, and where it passes the Chimestones shudder and stagger and the slow heavy certainty goes out of them. It costs you a jolt of it yourselves, a boom straight through the breastbone, and not one of you would take it back.

► **The fight can end without the last kill, and it is better if it does.** When the last Chimestone is stunned, or the win is no longer in doubt, put one beat of quiet on the table before anybody rolls again. If the party lowers their weapons and backs out of the shallows, the reef stands down: no check, no cost, it simply works, because an immune system does not chase what is already leaving. Do not offer this. Let a player think of it, exactly as with Thumpaw, and pay the idea in full when they do. In the Landing the kindness was the cut that set something free; here nothing is sick and nothing is bound, so the kindness is the strike withheld. If they finish the last one anyway, the fight was honest and nobody gets scolded; the chord is simply one note smaller on the way out, and Ghostbloom hears it.

You step back, and the reef notices that too.

The last Chimestone stands in the shallows with its amber eyes on you, ringing softly, and does not follow. Then, joint by heavy joint, it folds its legs back under itself and settles into the water, and it is a boulder again, and you would swear it had never been anything else. Around you the ringing comes down slowly, wild harmonics settling back into the old patient chord, the moss light steadying, the pool remembering how to ripple.

The reef has decided you are weather. Loud weather, strange weather, but the kind that passes, and it has stood through worse.

You take your rest inside a chord.

There has never been a stranger campsite and there may never be a better one. You eat sitting on warm stone with music coming up through it, the reef's slow ringing folded around you like a roof, and the notes change when the ground breathes, so the whole meal happens inside something enormous and calm that is almost a song. Ghostbloom hums along, quietly, the entire time, and nobody asks her to stop.

Years from now, when all of this is a story you tell, this is the note you will remember.

► **SHORT REST, right here.** Take it the moment the last Chimestone goes quiet, and say so at the table: Hit Dice spent, Stabby's Focus back, Ursa's Wild Shape back, Lilly's Aether Ward back. The Glassed Gallery is built assuming they walk in full, and it is not kind if they do not.

3. The Glassed Gallery: The Wound



The Glassed Gallery, where the corruption burned through and cooled.

You know something is wrong a hundred feet before you reach it, because the ground stops breathing.

Ahead of you the roots are **black glass**. Not burned: glassed, smooth and shining and hard, frozen mid-growth in the middle of reaching for something. The whole gallery is silent in a way nothing else down here has been. There is no moss light. Your own lamps look small. And every surface, when you get close, is covered in fine cracks that are very slowly, very quietly, spreading.

► **Let them feel the size of it.** This is not a monster's lair; it is a burn scar going outward at the speed of grass growing, and it has been going for two years. Nothing here needs a check to understand. The cracks all radiate from one direction, deeper in, toward the Hollow, and any hero who looks at them for ten seconds can say so out loud.

Stabby's idol has stopped being merely cold. It aches in the palm now, cold the way a nail left out in winter is cold, and after a minute of carrying it he has to wrap it in a fold of cloth and put it away. It has never once behaved like this.

► **Explain nothing.** No check identifies it, no NPC has a theory, and nobody down here reacts to it. It got colder near the ring, it is colder here, and that is the entire beat. Let his player sit with it.

The Sphere is brighter here than it has been anywhere in Underroot, bright enough that Lilly is holding it a little away from her body, and it is drinking hardest exactly where the glass is thickest. Whatever is bleeding out of this wound, her Sphere was built to gather it.

► **Give Lilly that deduction free**, no roll. It is the first hard evidence for the theory she spent her year building: the Sphere grows by going out, and a wound this size is a feast.

And then, from deeper in, past where the moss light died, you hear it: a sound of glass on glass, soft and patient and perfectly regular, like somebody sweeping a floor that will never

come clean.

It has been going a long time. It does not stop when you get closer.

► **Let them approach that sound as slowly as they like.** It is the Weeper, still at its work, and it pays them no attention at all until light finds it. There is no ambush waiting in this gallery, only a job that never ends, so heroes who scout get the full reveal below before anything moves.

Fight 3: The Glass Weeper

Something is still standing in the gallery. It has the shape of one of the big slow root-tenders: a long neck, a crown of fronds for combing the roots clean. It is far too tall to be one. It is black glass grown into the memory of a tender, a mimicry the corruption built up around something at its centre you cannot see, and the glass moves the way a hand moves a puppet. And the puppet is **still trying to do the job**, sweeping shattered glass fronds

through glassed roots that cannot feel it, over and over, patiently, forever.

Around its feet, rolling in fast, are lumps of black glassy coal the size of ripe pumpkins, each with one furious orange eye.

It does not notice you until your light touches it. Then the sweeping stops.

The long neck comes around. The crown of broken fronds opens like a black glass fan, and from somewhere deep inside the mimicry a thin note begins to rise, and every crack in the gallery sings along with it. The tenders of Underroot were made to clean their roots of anything that does not belong, and the puppet wearing this one's shape has just decided that what does not belong is you.





Stabby's proving ground: the Weeper knits itself back together, and the Nichirin answers.

► **The Cinderolls arrive two at a time**, so the pressure never stops and never quite swamps the party. Do not open with all four. The Weeper does not chase and never leaves its roots; it does not have to, because it reaches fifteen feet and hits three times a turn.

► This one is meant to be hard, and it has a lever. The Weeper regains **10 hit points at the start of its turn** unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by **Cleansing Edge**, since its last turn, so with ordinary steel every wound they open is part closed again before their next turn and the fight reads as if it is going backwards. **Stabby is the answer, and everyone at the table should be able to see it.** The second lever is kindness: any hero can spend an action tending the glassed roots the Weeper is bound to (**DC 14 Nature or Medicine**, or any healing spell cast on the roots instead of a creature). On a success the Weeper **loses its regeneration until the end of its next turn** and every attack against it has **advantage** until the start of the helper's next turn. Two or three of those and the fight tips hard. It never ends the encounter; it makes the party feel brilliant while they finish it. Meanwhile the Cinderolls roll twenty feet and detonate: let the players work out that popping one next to three others is a chain reaction, and let them enjoy it. Watch the Weeper's **Keening** (its wail: a 30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution, 21 psychic and frightened) landing on the same turn the roll-in pair arrives, and pull the fourth Cinderoll if the table is on the ropes.

► **The first time a hero tends the glassed roots, read the following.** This is the session's thesis at its saddest, and it must not be missed at the table: the lever is mechanical, but what it shows them is not. Wait for the room to go quiet before you start.

Warmth. That is the first surprise: the glassed root under your hands is not cold at all, and where you tend it the black glass clouds over, greys, and lets go. For the width of one finger there is green underneath. Living green, soft and damp and stubborn, the first colour this gallery has held in two years.

And across the gallery, the Weeper stops.

Its frond hangs in the air, mid-sweep. Slowly, by inches, the whole tall broken shape of it leans toward what you are doing, the way a tired thing leans toward a fire. For one long

breath it only watches the green, because somewhere inside the puppet, underneath the glass and the wrongness, something remembers this exact work, and remembers that it was worth doing.

► **And when somebody pops a Cinderoll next to its friends, read this one with a grin.** The fight has earned exactly one laugh, and this is where it lives.

One furious orange eye goes very wide, and then the whole cluster goes up together, pop, pop, POP, a string of festival crackers in the dark, and for one glorious second the Glassed Gallery is lit up gold, as if it remembers what light is.

When it finally falls it does not crumple. It **shatters**, all at once, a whole creature's worth of black glass coming apart across the floor with a noise like a window breaking in another room. And in the middle of the wreckage, curled up small where its heart should have been, is an ordinary little animal. Grey fur. Four paws. It has been dead for two years, and something built a statue around it and kept it working.

► **This is where the session stops being an adventure and becomes a rescue**, and it is the last beat before Groudon. Do not narrate it gruesomely and do not linger: one quiet image, then silence at the table, then let a player be the one to speak first.

Afterward, Stabby walks out into the gallery alone. He lights his breath, and sets the burning edge against the black glass.

► **Stop there and hand the narration to Stabby's player.** This image is the whole point of his year, so let him be the one who says what the glass does. No check, no cost, no roll. If he stalls, offer him the picture and let him carry it from there: where the Nichirin passes, the black glass **flinches**, it greys, it dulls, it crumbles back into ordinary soil, exactly the way the blight recoiled from him on the mountain at home. The path stays clean behind them.

He cannot heal this place. It is a mile wide and he is very small. What he can do is burn a clean path straight through the middle of it, and that is the road you walk out on.

You are not fifty steps along that road when Ursa stops walking, and then all of you hear it. Behind you, faint as a sleeper turning over, at the very edge of feeling, the ground along the clean path has begun to breathe again: one narrow road's width of Underroot, remembering how. Nobody says anything for a while, and it is a good kind of quiet.

Past the wound the tunnel narrows, then steepens, then simply ends, and everything they have felt underfoot all day turns out to have had a source.

4. Groudon's Hollow: The Guardian



Groudon's Hollow. The shape in the distance is not a hill.

The tunnel ends and there is no floor, only a drop into a chamber so large that your light does not find the far side of it.

Something down there is breathing. You have been feeling it since you arrived, the slow swell of the ground every minute or so, and now you understand what you have been standing on top of all day. It was never the plane breathing.

It was **him**.

He fills the hollow: a mountain with a spine, red-brown plates the size of barn doors, claws sunk deep into stone he has not moved from in a very long time. Glowing seams of magma run down his flanks like veins. And driven into his back, up near the shoulder where he cannot possibly reach it, is a **spike of black glass**, and every crack in this world spreads outward from that one point.

He is the reason there is dry land anywhere. And he is in agony, and he has been for two years, and he has not been able to tell anyone.



Groudon, the Continent-Maker, with two years of black glass driven into his shoulder.

The Fight, and What It Is Actually About



The spike, the Glasslings, and the mountain that never asked for any of it.

► **Groudon is not the villain. The spike is.** This is the Grand Custodian rule from Gearhaven at ten times the scale: *free the guardian and the cracks close*. Say the rule out loud at the table if the players do not reach for it themselves, because the whole encounter is built on it. Nobody is killing a god tonight.

► **Do not let the party win by damage.** Groudon has **AC 18 and 230 hit points** and hits hard enough to drop a level-7 hero in two turns. A straight brawl is a loss, and it is supposed to be. **The win condition is the spike:** a hard target on his back with **AC 17 and 60 hit points, immune to everything except radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge**. Reaching it means climbing him (Athletics or Acrobatics), flying (Stabby's Sash, Ursa's Starry Form), or a called shot at range with disadvantage. **When the spike breaks, the encounter ends instantly.** Not "he has forty hit points left." It ends, whatever his total is. Do not run him to 0. He is not supposed to die, and nothing in this room is an execution.

► **When someone first lays a hand on Groudon to climb,** read the following.

Your hand finds the edge of a plate the size of a barn door, and the first surprise is the heat: not burning, but deep, like a stone hearth hours after the fire has died, warmth that comes from a very long way inside. The second surprise is the heartbeat. It rolls up through your palms, slow and enormous, and you feel it in your teeth and in the soles of your boots, like standing inside a drum the size of a hill while someone patient beats out the oldest rhythm there is.

You are climbing something alive. He is older than the land you were born on. He is in more pain than anything you have ever touched. And he does not know, he cannot know, that the small warm thing clinging to his shoulder is trying to help.

Hold on. Keep climbing.

► **The moment Ursa reaches out with the Mark,** the way Selarin taught him, read the following. He goes in expecting rage.

There is no rage in there at all. There is a wall of pain so old and so patient that it has stopped being a feeling and started being weather, and underneath it, very faint, something that has been trying to say one word for two years and has no mouth to say it with.

Help.

► **Only Ursa can feel this, and telling the others is the moment the fight becomes a rescue.** Give his player the line and let him deliver it in his own words. If nobody reaches for the Mark, let the Agony shockwave do the job instead: he screams when it hits him, and it hits him every single turn.

The Glasslings

► **The spike creates one Glassling at the start of each of Groudon's turns:** a cat-sized scuttling thing of black glass that drops off his back and goes straight for the nearest warm body. They are weak, they burst when killed (**DC 12 Dexterity, 5 slashing, 5 ft**), and they never stop coming. They exist to answer the obvious question, which is why not ignore the spike and whittle Groudon from range: because the longer the spike lives, the more little glass things are chewing on the party.

► **When the spike breaks, every Glassling on the board collapses into ordinary sand at once,** wherever it is and whatever it was doing. Clear them off the map in one sweep of your hand and say nothing while you do it.



Groudon's Turns

► **Play him as a natural disaster with a wounded animal inside it**, never as a tactician. He does not aim, he does not focus fire, he does not plan. Alternate: **Continental Step** (he moves, the floor changes, DC 16 Dexterity within 30 ft of his path or knocked prone for 11 bludgeoning), **Magma Vent** (recharge 4-6, a 60-ft line 10 ft wide, DC 17 Dexterity, 35 fire, half on a success), **Claw** (+12 to hit, reach 15 ft, 24 slashing) if anything is in reach, and **Thrash** whenever the spike takes damage (once a round, no action: every creature climbing him makes a DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check or falls for 3d6). Remember **Agony**: while the spike is intact, at the start of each of his turns he takes 10 damage himself and everything within 20 ft makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or takes 10 bludgeoning from the shockwave. He is being hurt in front of them, every round, and they can see it.

► **Mercy rule, and it is not optional.** If a hero drops, Groudon immediately moves away from them. He does not finish anyone, ever. He does not know they are there in any meaningful way; he is swatting at pain, not hunting children. Tell the table that out loud the first time it happens.

► The shape of this encounter is simple to say and hard to do: survive a very large angry mountain long enough for somebody to climb his back and cut the thing that is hurting him out of it. Every hero has a job. **Stabby is the one who ends this, and the entire session has been building to it**: speed 65 with his breath lit, Step of the Wind to close, and a Nichirin that is one of only three things in this world that can touch the spike at all. He climbs a mountain that is trying to shake him off and he cuts the corruption out of a god. **Do not let anybody else take that blow unless his player hands it over**; if the dice go badly, let Ursa's summon pin Groudon in place or Lilly's Flash of Genius rescue the climb check, so the last strike is still his. **Ursa** keeps everyone standing, drops a summon between Groudon and whoever is climbing, and is the only one who can feel that the creature is in pain. **Lilly** shoots the spike from range and holds the party together with Aether Ward; force damage from Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles hits the spike and never misses. When the sixty hit points are gone, stop rolling. Put the dice down, let the Glasslings fall to sand, and play what follows as a rescue landing rather than a victory lap: the party did not kill anything in this room, they took a splinter out of a mountain's shoulder, and the mountain is going to look at them.

► One timing note on the box below: if the dice have made someone other than Stabby the finisher, that stands, but if the spike is still reachable for him, offer the blow to Stabby's player first, because this is the swing the whole session has been climbing toward.

► **When the last hit is about to land on the spike**, pause the table before the roll, and read:

The crack you have been carving in the black glass widens, one bright hairline racing through the dark.

The sick light inside the spike stutters and gutters like a candle at the bottom of its wax. And for one breath, one single breath, the whole hollow goes quiet: the magma seams dim to embers, the last Glasslings go still, and the mountain beneath you holds himself motionless, as if something in him, deeper down than two years of pain, knows what is coming and is waiting for it.

One more hit. That is all it needs.

Swing.

The Way Home

When the Spike Breaks



The moment the sick light goes out of him.

The black glass does not shatter.

It comes apart the way a held breath is let go, all at once and quietly, into a spray of dark motes that hang in the air for a single heartbeat and then rush, every one of them together, into the Sphere in Lilly's hands.

And the mountain stops.

Groudou goes absolutely still. Then he lowers himself down onto his belly on the stone with a sound like a hillside settling, and he lets out a breath that goes on so long that somebody laughs, once, out of pure nerves, and every root in the hollow shivers along its whole enormous length.

Then he turns his head, slowly, and looks at the three of you properly for the first time.

He is not angry. He is so tired.

► Everything after the spike is the part they will remember. Slow down. This is not the end of a fight; it is the end of two years of somebody's pain, and the whole session has been walking toward it.

► **The encounter ends the instant the spike drops, whatever his hit points are.** Do not roll another attack, do not finish the round, do not let anybody get one more hit in. And **every Glassling on the board collapses into ordinary sand where it stands**, mid-lunge, mid-bite, all of them at once. Clear the miniatures off the table with your hands while the players are still watching. That clatter is the applause line of the whole session.

As the last of the glass leaves him, something else comes loose from the wound in his shoulder. It is a fist-sized ember of packed red-brown light, dense as a river stone and warm as bread, and it does not fall. It drifts, unhurried, across the hollow and settles against the

Sphere like an animal finding the right place to sleep.

This is the **Mote of Terra**: the piece of this world's heart that was caught here, come home to the only thing in the room built to carry it.

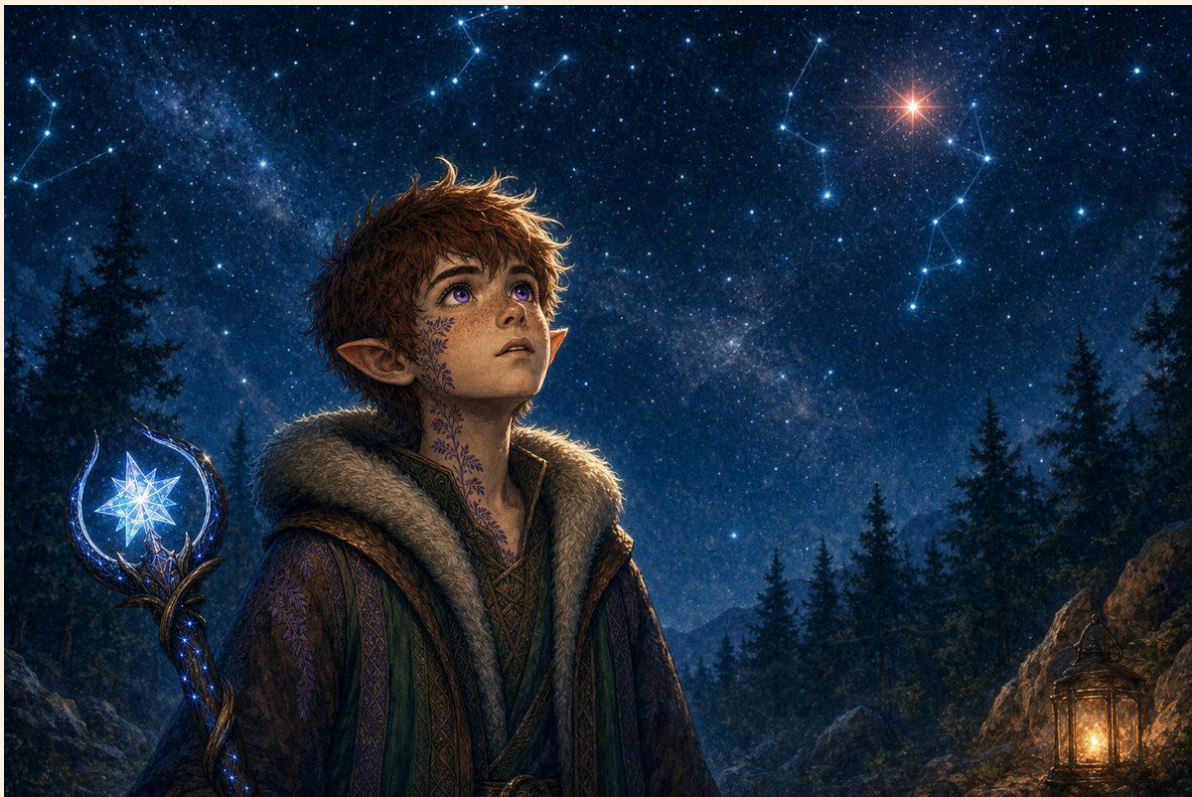
Groudon gathers himself, and the floor of the world remembers what it is for. He reaches out one claw, a thing that has moved continents, and sets the very tip of it on the ground in front of **Ursa**, with a care that would not crack an egg.

Nobody needs a Mark to understand that.

Then he begins to walk. And where he walks, the cracks close behind him like a seam being pulled shut, and away off in the dark you can hear the glassed gallery greying and crumbling back into plain, ordinary, breathing soil.

► **Give Ursa the line if his player wants it.** He is the only one who can feel what the creature is feeling, and what it is feeling is *relief*. Let him say it out loud to the other two. That sentence is what turns the boss fight into a rescue in everybody's memory, and it should come out of a player's mouth, not yours.

Antares



In the east, over the roofs of Gearhaven, a star comes back.

You come out into lamplight and noise and Vane shouting three questions at once, and it is a long few minutes before anybody thinks to look up.

Ursa does.

Through the high windows of the Rift Hall, over the wet slate roofs of Gearhaven, there is a star in the east that was dying.

It is not dying now. It is the deep, steady, unbothered red it is supposed to be, the colour it is in every one of his father's charts. His father spent a year drawing a star getting fainter, month after month, and then he put the pen down and walked east to do something about it,

and in all the watching since, nobody has ever seen one come back. This one has.

► **Only Ursa understands what he is looking at, and that is the point.** He watched Antares dim on the night they left and said nothing to anybody; he has spent a year with those charts. Let his player be the one to explain it to the others, in his own words, at his own speed. Then let **Aelwyn** go very quiet, because a man who has been arguing a theory for thirty years has just watched it become a fact.

► **The Staff of Waking Constellations answers.** One new star kindles on the haft and stays lit. That is what the staff was made for, and this is the first time anyone has seen it work.

The Sphere Will Not Settle



One goes in so another can come out: the roster begins.

It has been getting brighter since Underroot, and now it is too bright to look at straight. It is warm as a stove top. It hums against Lilly's palms hard enough to make her teeth ache. Aelwyn takes one look at it and tells everybody to stand back, and for once he is not delighted. He is **nervous**, which is very much worse.

"It gathered more than it can hold," he says. "It only keeps one shape at a time."

"So what happens?" says Lilly.

"It is going to have to choose."

Ghostbloom chooses first.

Nobody asks her to. Nobody gets the chance. She drifts around in front of Lilly so that they are eye to eye, and she chimes, once, the small clear note she has been making since a foggy path above the sea two years ago.

Then she steps into the light and is gone, and the Sphere goes calm in Lilly's hands, and the room is very quiet.

► **Play this straight and let it hurt for three or four seconds.** The kids will think they have just lost her. They have not: she is the tether, she is perfectly fine, she is aware in there and she can come back out tonight. Aelwyn explains all of that in a moment. Do not rush to reassure them before the moment lands, and do not stretch it past four seconds either. Count it in your head.

And then the light in Lilly's hands stands up.

The gathered essence of a whole plane pulls itself into a shape, and what steps out of the glow, blinking in the lamplight and thoroughly unimpressed by all of you, is the small armoured digger from Mossflight Landing. Yellow-brown plates. Enormous claws. Very much solid. Very much real. It shakes itself the way a dog does, and a little Underroot soil scatters across Vane's clean workshop floor.



Sandshrew, come home out of the light with somebody else's dirt still on his claws.

► **Where he goes matters.** If the party was kind to him at Mossflight Landing, or fed him, he walks straight to whoever did it. If they were unkind, he crosses the room to **Ursa** and settles against his boot, and on the way he goes right past the hero who chased him off without once looking up. **Then say nothing.** Do not explain it, do not soften it, do not offer that player a consolation line, and do not let Aelwyn talk over the silence. The table will work out what just happened on its own, and it should.

"The Sphere gathers," Aelwyn says, crouching down to be polite about it. "That is all it has ever done. Today it gathered an entire world's worth of loose essence, and essence gathers toward warmth, and toward company. So it brought somebody home."

► **Teach the companion-swap rule right here, before anybody goes home.** The full script, in the words to say it, is in the run sheet appendix under **The Companion Swap**. Teach it, then hand Sandshrew over and let them run the first swap themselves, right there in the workshop, so Ghostbloom steps back out where they can all see her.

REWARDS: WHAT UNDERROOT GAVE THEM

The concrete gains, once the shouting in the Rift Hall dies down

Sandshrew. A companion, freely given, gathered out of the essence of a whole plane. He digs, he takes a hit, and he is made of the same stuff as the ground he stands on. **Second on the roster, and the first proof that the roster is real.**

Ghostbloom, the Tether. Unharmed and unchanged, riding inside the Sphere as its anchor and stepping back out on request. The Sphere holds **one** physical companion at a time; the swap is Lilly's Action.

The Mote of Terra. The piece of Underroot's heart that was caught in this world, socketed into the Sphere. **The rift is closed.** Not patched, not held: closed, by a guardian walking home.

Tectonic Slam. Lilly's **first Elemental Discharge**, woken by the Mote of Terra. Four sockets in the Sphere stay dark, and she can feel every one of them.

A New Star on the Staff. Antares is lit. One new star kindles on the haft of the Staff of Waking Constellations and stays lit, which is precisely what the staff was made to do.

What Each of Them Carries Home

Lilly gets the thing she spent a year arguing for: proof. Her power grows by going out, exactly as she worked it out alone at a bench in Gearhaven, and now there is a Mote in a socket and a discharge in her hands that nobody built for her.

Late that night she has the Sphere open on the workbench, the Mote sitting in its new socket, and she is not looking at anybody.

"It isn't full. That's the thing. There's a whole *plane* in there and it barely moved the needle."

She turns it over in her hands. "I can feel where the other four go. There are sockets, and they're empty, and when I put my hand flat on it I can almost hear what it would sound like with all five."

"I don't think it's a battery. I think it's an instrument. And I've only ever played one note on it."

► **What that plants:** her ceiling is very high and entirely gated on rifts cleared. She has gone from one discharge to a promise of five in a single night, and she is the only person at this table who can feel the shape of the thing she is going to become. Let her player sit with that.

Ursa carries home a relit star and the first hard evidence anybody has ever had that the damage can be *undone*. He also carries the beginning of a private worry, and he does not share it: the spike did not grow in Groudon's back. Somebody drove it in, on purpose, by hand. And he brought a name back from a shrine on a mountain.

Stabby carries a katana that did something no other blade in the world could do, and one small fact he has told nobody. The idol went cold when they stepped through the ring, colder in the glassed gallery, and it warmed the instant they came back. He noticed exactly when. He has not mentioned it.

Threads to Leave Hanging

► **One: who drove the spike in?** Nobody says a name at the table tonight, and neither do you. But the party has now seen with their own eyes that the rifts are not weather. Somebody is doing this, by hand, one world at a time.

Two: the idol. Cold at the threshold, colder at the gallery, warm at home. Never explain it. Just keep doing it.

Three: four stars to go, and two of them are still bright. Aelwyn will work out what that means

before the next session is over: if the lights are being put out one by one, then somewhere out there is a star nobody has reached yet, and the party can get there **first**.

It is very late. Vane has finally stopped talking. Sandshrew has fallen asleep in a crate of brass fittings and nobody has the heart to move him.

Aelwyn is standing at the high window with his hands behind his back, looking east, at a star that spent two years dying and is not dying anymore.

He says it to nobody at all.

"One."

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ **The Second List**

The Circle has kept its list of stars for forty generations, and in all that time the scribes have only ever done one thing to it: cross names out. There is no mark in their book for a name coming back, because nobody ever needed one. The eldest sky-reader alive was asked, once, what the Circle would do if a dark star ever relit. She thought about it for a long while. Then she said: begin a second list.

APPENDIX

The DM's Run Sheet

Every DC, dial, and spotlight, in play order. Keep this page at your elbow.

The Shape of the Session

► **PART ONE is read, not rolled.** Seven days early: Lilly alone in the Rift Hall, Vane too loud and sleeping too little, and the cradle that does not quite fit until the sixth night, when it does → THE PROFESSOR: Aelwyn Ravenstone, three trunks, no help, and Lickgloom recognising the party (the only uncomplicated happy reunion all night) → DAWN AT THE EASTERN GATE: Ursa on foot, taller and quieter, turning a stone over in his left hand → TEN TO MIDNIGHT: Stabby off the rail without a sound, and **the idol knocks against the flagstones cold enough to burn** → THE THREE CHAPTERS, read in full, in this order: Lilly (the most hopeful), Stabby (the loudest), Ursa (NYXTHID, and it changes the campaign, so it goes last) → THE HANDOVER: hand out the level 7 sheets here, teach the traps in a quiet room → THE BRIEFING: five facts, and say the one about losing the Sphere exactly once → THE LESSON: slow, no sky, indifferent, and free the guardian → THE THRESHOLD.

PART TWO is played on the Underroot board. The party moves as ONE token: a player rolls **1d6**, moves that many spaces, and the token passes to the next kid on the next roll. The colour they land on resolves at once, and **the die they just moved with picks the outcome: even or odd.** No table to look up, no second roll. The four numbered locations are not dots: the token stops at each one whatever movement is left, the beat plays, and movement resumes next turn. THE RIFT GATE (arrival, no fight, one safe scene to be amazed) → MOSSLIGHT LANDING and the Sandshrew (**FIGHT 1**) → CHIME REEF (**FIGHT 2**) → **SHORT REST, immediately after the reef, called out loud** → THE GLASSED GALLERY (**FIGHT 3**), and the small creature curled inside the glass that turns the adventure into a rescue → GROUDON'S HOLLOW (**BOSS**): the spike breaks, the Mote of Terra comes home → back through the ring, and Ursa looks up at Antares → THE HOMECOMING: Ghostbloom steps into the Sphere, Sandshrew steps out, the swap rule gets taught, and Aelwyn says one word to nobody.

The natural break point is the Threshold. Part One ends the moment the air inside the ring stops being air; if the evening has to stop somewhere, stop it there and start the next one on the far side. Inside Part Two the second-best pause is the short rest after the reef. **Pace check:** there are 22 dots between the gate and the Hollow, and they are texture, not the session. If the night is running long, hand-wave the dots between the Gallery and the Hollow and go straight to Groudon. Never let a garnet dot swell into a fifth big fight.

RUNS ALL SESSION. The Sphere is pulling, warm in Lilly's hands from the first breath of Underroot, and it does not stop; it drinks fastest where the damage is worst. **Ursa cannot navigate:** no sky, no stars, and his year of star-reading buys him nothing, so give him advantage on Survival for reading root growth and soil, exactly as Selarin told him. **The idol gets colder the deeper they go,** and you never explain it. **Ghostbloom is delighted,** a plant-spirit inside a plane made of growing things, right up until the Hollow. And **nothing here can be talked down, waited out, or avoided:** the levers below turn grinding fights into satisfying ones, they are never an off-ramp.

Fights at a Glance

FIGHT 1: Mosslight Landing (warm-up, but it runs long; it teaches the session's rule). 6x Rotbloom (AC 12, HP 22; **Re-Bloom**: it regains 5 HP at the start of its turn if it took damage and is not at 0; Cap Slam +3 for 2d4+1; Spore Puff, recharge 5-6, a 10-ft cone, DC 12 Constitution or 2d6 poison and poisoned) + 6x Mossmite (AC 13, HP 7, Speed 40 ft and climb 40 ft; Skitter, no opportunity attacks; Pack Nerve; Nip +5 for 1d4+3), boiling out of the moss the moment the first Rotbloom is struck. **THE LEVER: Cleansing Edge**. A Rotbloom cannot re-bloom if it has taken radiant damage or been hit by Cleansing Edge since its last turn, and Stabby is the only reliable source at this table. Let the party flail for one round, let Lilly and Ursa watch their damage undo itself, then let him cut one and have it **stay** cut. **The tell**: the Rotblooms do not attack the Sandshrew and it does not run from them. Corruption does not eat its own.

FIGHT 2: Chime Reef (hard on paper, easy the moment somebody thinks of thunder). 3x Chimestone (AC 16, HP 52, **VULNERABLE THUNDER**, tremorsense 60 ft; Multiattack two Crystal Rams at +6 for 2d6+4; Shard Volley +6 for 2d8 at 40 ft) + 3x Shardwing (AC 14, HP 22, fly 50 ft, **VULNERABLE THUNDER**; Dive +6 for 2d6+2, plus 1d6 more if it came 30 ft straight in; Shard Spit +6 for 1d10+2 at 60 ft). **THE LEVER: Resonant Body**. Any thunder damage **stuns a Chimestone until the end of its next turn, and it takes DOUBLE damage from every source while stunned**. Thunderwave and Shatter turn a wall into a free kill. Better still, anyone can spend an action striking a big spire (**DC 13 Athletics**): every Chimestone within 30 ft makes a **DC 14 Constitution save** or is stunned the same way, and the striker takes 1d6 thunder for standing that close. Nobody minds. Lilly's Arcana read: the crystals are growing toward something deeper in. It is Groudon.

FIGHT 3: The Glassed Gallery (the hardest thing before the boss, and Stabby's proving ground). 1x Glass Weeper (AC 16, HP 115; **Glassbound**: regains 10 HP at the start of its turn unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn; Rooted, it never leaves its glassed roots by more than 15 ft; Multiattack three Frond Lashes at +7 for 2d6+5 with 15 ft of reach; Keening, recharge 5-6, a 30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution for 6d6 psychic and frightened) + 4x Cinderoll (AC 15, HP 18, Speed 40 ft rolling, **arriving two at a time**; Rolling Charge adds 1d6 and a DC 12 Strength save or prone; **Burst** at 0 HP, DC 12 Dexterity within 10 ft or 2d6 fire; Slam +4 for 2d4+2 plus 1d6 fire). **THE LEVER: Tend the Roots**. An action clearing or healing the glassed roots (**DC 14 Nature or Medicine**, or any healing spell aimed at the roots rather than a creature) strips Glassbound until the end of the Weeper's next turn and gives everyone **advantage** on attacks against it until the start of the helper's next turn. Two or three of those and the fight tips hard. Let the kids chain a Cinderoll off its neighbours; that is what packs of them are for.

BOSS: Groudon's Hollow (the rescue, not the kill). Groudon (AC 18, HP 230, tremorsense 120 ft, CR 11; **Continental Step**: he moves, and everything on the ground within 30 ft of his path makes a **DC 16 Dexterity save** or takes 2d10 and is knocked prone; **Magma Vent**, recharge 4-6, a 60-ft line 10 ft wide, **DC 17 Dexterity** for 10d6 fire, half on a success; **Claw** +12 for 3d10+8 at 15 ft; **Agony**: while the spike is intact he takes 10 damage at the start of each of his turns and everything within 20 ft makes a **DC 16 Dexterity save** or takes 3d6 from the shockwave) + Glasslings (AC 14, HP 10; Glass Bite +5 for 1d6+3; Shatterburst at 0 HP, DC 12 Dexterity within 5 ft for 2d4), **one spawned at the start of each of Groudon's turns**. **THE LEVER IS THE ONLY WIN CONDITION: THE SPIKE**. AC 17, 60 hit points, immune to everything except **radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge**, reached by climbing, by flight, or by a ranged attack at disadvantage. Damaging it triggers **Thrash** (once a round, no action): every climber makes a **DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check** or falls for 3d6. **When the spike breaks the fight ends instantly**, whatever his hit points are, and every Glassling on the board collapses into sand in the same heartbeat. Do not

run him to 0. He is not supposed to die, and **He Does Not Finish Them**: a hero who drops is left alone, because he is swatting at pain, not hunting children.

THE ROAD BETWEEN (garnet dots only, small pressure, never a fifth big fight). **Even:** **Thumpaw** (1x, AC 14, HP 76; two Shovel Slams at +8 for 2d8+5; Immovable; Not Actually Angry, so it never starts it, never pursues, and never finishes a downed hero). A straight brawl with no gimmick, on purpose. Do not offer the way out; if they think of befriending it themselves, **DC 15 Animal Handling**, with advantage from Ursa's Mark, moves it aside. **Odd: the Gleamoth** (3x swarm, AC 12, HP 26, fly 40 ft hover, resist bludgeoning, piercing and slashing, **VULNERABLE FIRE AND THUNDER**; Smother +4 for 4d4, or 2d4 at half HP, and blinded until the end of its next turn). They chase the warmest, brightest thing in the tunnel, which is the Sphere, so the swarm sits on Lilly all fight and the party has to come to her. **The other dots, even then odd:** moss gives the Deepwater Spring (1 Hit Die back, one level of exhaustion cleared) or the Shortcut (advance the token 3 spaces free, and only if they were kind at the Landing); ochre gives Sinkloam (**DC 13 Strength** or restrained, heavy armour at disadvantage, so somebody has to go back for Lilly) or the Ceiling Lets Go (**DC 14 Dexterity**, 2d10 bludgeoning, half on a success, and the way back is shut); amethyst gives the Reef Answers (**2d8 temporary hit points** for everyone, and a fine place for the short rest if they have not taken it) or the Guardian's Dream (no mechanical effect, and Ursa may regain one spent omen).

The Resource Picture

► One evening, one long day underground, and **exactly one short rest inside it**: immediately after the Chime Reef. Call it by name at the table, because four things come back on it and the players need to see the shape of that: **Hit Dice**, **Stabby's Focus** (7, and Igniting the Breath costs 1 while Devour refunds its own on a kill), **one of Ursa's three Wild Shape uses** (Starry Form spends one and runs 10 minutes), and **both of Lilly's Aether Wards** (2d8 + 5 temporary hit points to her and every friend within 30 ft, twice per short rest). The Reef Answers dot hands out 2d8 temporary hit points and the Deepwater Spring gives back a Hit Die and a level of exhaustion, so the road can quietly pay for a rough fight. What to watch: **Stabby's Focus across four fights plus whatever the dots throw**, because he is the answer to three of them and cannot afford to arrive at the spike empty; **Ursa's concentration**, one thing at a time, and his Wild Shape, since Starry Form and a summon are competing for the same three uses; **Lilly's Aether Ward**, which is the party's only pre-emptive shield and wants spending before Magma Vent, not after; and **Ghostbloom's Guardian's Light** (a reaction within 30 ft, 2d8 + 3 and it ends charmed or frightened, three times a short rest), which is the safety net for the whole run. She carries it all night and only steps into the Sphere at the very end, so nothing about it changes until the homecoming. Lilly's **Flash of Genius** (+5 to a failed check or save for her or a friend within 30 ft, five times a day) is the spare: hold at least one for the climb up Groudon's back.

Spotlights & Seeds: every kid shines, every door gets planted

Lilly: she is on the ground seven days early because she cannot stand waiting anywhere else → the cradle Vane built from a description closes around the real Sphere as though it were cut for it → her chapter is the year of questions, ending on a workshop floor with the marks under the brass and the sentence that reframes everything: **her mother did not make it, her mother found it, and it**

is a gatherer → the Handover is hers, six gifts on three cloths and not one of them made for herself first → in Underroot the Sphere pulls from the first breath and she is the only one who can say why → her Arcana at the reef reads the crystals leaning toward something deeper in → in the Gallery the Sphere is visibly drinking, and she works out that the loose essence bleeding out of this wound is exactly what it was built to collect → at the Hollow she is the ranged answer to the spike, and **force damage from Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles never misses it** → the Mote of Terra comes home and **Tectonic Slam wakes**. (Doors: four empty sockets and a ceiling gated entirely on rifts cleared; and somebody, a very long time ago, built the thing her mother only housed. Give her the workbench beat that night: it is not a battery, it is an instrument, and she has only ever played one note on it.)

Stabby: he arrives ten minutes early and pretends otherwise, and the idol hits the flagstones cold enough to burn → his chapter is the loudest in the book: **he was never unteachable, he was occupied**, the Fourth was his father, the Red Fang is older than the Hollow, and the whole test on Kettlecrown was holding still for one second → he came home and burned the blight out of the ground, and the clan that agreed he was not worth teaching offered him his father's seat, and he said not yet → **Fight 1 is built to hand him the session:** Cleansing Edge is the only thing at the table that makes a Rotbloom stay cut, and it is the first time anyone else has seen his year work. Say it out loud when it lands → **Fight 3 is his proving ground:** the Weeper claws back 10 a round, so every wound they open is part shut by the time it comes round to them again, and he is the reason it is winnable, and afterward let him walk the glassed roots with his breath lit and burn a clean road out of the wound for everyone else to walk → **the boss is his:** Speed 65 ignited, Step of the Wind to close, and the Nichirin is one of only three things in the world that can touch the spike. He climbs a mountain that is trying to shake him off and he cuts the corruption out of a god. Do not let anybody else take that unless his player hands it over; if the dice go badly, rescue the climb with Ursa's summon or Lilly's Flash of Genius so the last blow is still his. (Doors: the idol he has told nobody about, and a seat he did not say never to.)

Ursa: he comes in with the dawn traffic, taller and half a beat slower to answer, turning his father's half-carved stone over and over → his chapter goes last because it moves the campaign: the cairn road Ash built going out and Ursa repaired going in, the camp nobody said goodbye to, wood growth that reads **three years, not fifteen**, and a vision that gives him **Maldrith** and then hands him **Nyxthid** the way you hand somebody a weapon → at the Rift Gate, tell his player directly that the sky is gone and his year of star-reading buys him nothing down here, then give him advantage on Survival for reading the ground, which is what Selarin actually told him → the **Mark of Handling works on the Sandshrew**, and that should be the moment his player understands the plane's wildlife is not the enemy → he is the party's engine room all run: healing, control, and a summon between Groudon and whoever is climbing → and he is the only creature in the Hollow who can **feel that the guardian is in pain**. Telling the others is the moment the fight stops being a boss and becomes a rescue → afterward, in Gearhaven lamplight, he is the only one who looks up, and **Antares is the deep steady red it is supposed to be**, the first star in living memory to come back. One new star brightens on the Staff of Waking Constellations, which is exactly what it was made for. (Doors: a father who was alive three years ago, a name to hunt, and four stars still to go.)

Foreshadow Tracker: say it, then say it again

► The tells, in order, and every one of them pays later. **ANTARES:** Ursa looks up at the Threshold, sees it dimming, and says nothing (do not spend that beat); he looks up again on the way home and it is burning steady, and he is the only person alive who understands what that means. Aelwyn goes

very quiet, because a theory just became a fact, and his last line of the night is one word: One. • **THE IDOL:** it hits the flagstones cold enough to burn when Stabby drops his pack, forty feet from a portal that is not even lit; it goes cold **again** at the Threshold, hard enough that he notices; it is colder still at the Rift Gate and painful enough in the Glassed Gallery that he wraps it in cloth to carry it; and it is **warm** the instant they come back through, and he notices exactly when, and tells nobody. Never explain it. • **NYXTHID**, named aloud for the first time in this campaign, in Ursa's vision, with **Maldrith** pressing behind the last wall. Keep the figure featureless: no face, no build, nothing anybody can match to a person later. If a player asks, it looked like a hole in the shape of a person. • **THE HALF-CARVED STONE:** Elaria's seven-pointed star in his father's hand, the line stopping mid-stroke the way a pen stops when somebody says your name, warm since the day he picked it up. • **PIKACHU AS A KEY:** the spark spoke in dread-images through the Mark in Gearhaven, of a vast hunger, a herald-shadow, and itself as *a key. To something*. Nobody has asked to what, and this session quietly proves the Sphere gathers whatever is loose, friend or scrap alike. • **THE GUILD-STAMPED CRATES:** the essence-harvest crates in the Dutchman's hold wore the Gearhaven Artificers' Guild seal and were bound south, and this whole session is spent standing in that Guild's own Underworks, being helped, by people nobody has thought to ask about it. Do not resolve it. Let one crate in the background of the Rift Hall carry the same stamp, and say nothing at all.

The Companion Swap: the rule, and the words to say it

► **Teach this properly and teach it tonight.** It is the mechanic the rest of the campaign runs on, and this is its first outing. Say it in this order, in these words, small enough for the youngest player to repeat back:

One out at a time. The Sphere holds one companion in the world. Everybody else rides inside it, safe and awake and perfectly fine.

Swapping is Lilly's Action. She calls the name, the one outside steps into the light, and the one she called steps out. "Sandshrew, I choose you!" That is the whole ritual, and yes, she should get to say it out loud.

Nobody ever dies in there. A companion knocked to **0 hit points faints**, the Sphere recalls it on the spot, and it is not lost, not hurt for keeps, not gone. Promise that once and never break it.

Choose before you go, not in the middle. Ghostbloom heals and senses planar things; Sandshrew digs and takes hits and is made of the same stuff as the ground. Picking wrong for a plane is a real mistake and an entirely survivable one, which is exactly what makes it an interesting decision.

► **The roster grows by one per rift. Say that out loud tonight.** Four more planes, four more companions. The kids should start arguing about who they want next before the dishes are done, and they will be right to. Then hand Sandshrew over and **let them run the first swap themselves**, right there in the workshop, just to prove it works and get Ghostbloom back out where they can see her.

APPENDIX

Bestiary: Enemy Stat Blocks

Every creature of Underroot, in the order the party meets them.

ENEMIES, Fight 1: Mosslight Landing

Mosslight Landing ♦ Difficulty: Warm-up ♦ 6x Rotbloom + 6x Mossmite

ROTBLOOM

Small plant (corrupted), unaligned ♦ CR 1/2 (100 XP) ♦ 6 in the grey moss



AC 12 **HP** 22 (4d6 + 8) **Speed** 25 ft
STR 10 **DEX** 12 **CON** 14 **INT** 4 **WIS** 8 **CHA** 6
Resist poison **Imm.** (cond) blinded, deafened, poisoned
Senses blindsight 30 ft, passive Perception 9
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Traits

Re-Bloom. At the start of its turn, if it took damage since its last turn and is not at 0 HP, it regains 5 hit points. It cannot re-bloom if it has taken radiant damage, or been hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn.

Still Smiling. It cannot be frightened, and its face never changes, whatever is happening to it.

Actions

Cap Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (2d4 + 1) bludgeoning damage.

Spore Puff (Recharge 5-6). 10-ft cone, DC 12 Constitution save: 7 (2d6) poison damage and poisoned until the end of its next turn; half damage and no poisoning on a success.

MOSSMITE

Tiny beast (corrupted), unaligned ♦ CR 1/8 (25 XP) ♦ 6 boiling out of the moss



AC 13 **HP** 7 (2d4 + 2) **Speed** 40 ft, climb 40 ft
STR 6 **DEX** 16 **CON** 12 **INT** 2 **WIS** 10 **CHA** 4
Senses blindsight 30 ft, passive Perception 10
Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

Traits

Skitter. It does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Pack Nerve. It has advantage on attacks against a creature if another Mossmite is within 5 ft of it.

Actions

Nip. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage.

Tactics: This fight exists to hand Stabby the session. The Rotblooms swell back up out of their own caps every round, and ordinary steel keeps handing that ground back: only radiant damage or Cleansing Edge shuts Re-Bloom off. Let the party flail for a round and let Lilly and Ursa watch pieces of their damage close up again, then let Stabby ignite, cut one, and have it stay cut. The Mossmites boil out of the moss the moment the first Rotbloom is struck, and they are there to keep everyone honest while the real problem regrows behind them: individually harmless, collectively a swarm that punishes anyone who stands still. Six Rotblooms hitting in a cloud means Spore Puff has the whole party rolling saves, so this is a proper scrap rather than a speed bump. The tell to plant quietly: nothing here attacks the little armoured digger watching from the mound, and it does not run from them. Corruption does not eat its own.

ENEMIES, Fight 2: Chime Reef

The Chime Reef ♦ Difficulty: Hard, or easy the moment they use thunder ♦ 3x Chimestone + 3x Shardwing

CHIMESTONE

Medium elemental (Plane of Earth), unaligned ♦ CR 3 (700 XP) ♦ 3 standing up out of the shallows



AC 16 (rock plate) **HP** 52 (7d8 + 21) **Speed** 25 ft
STR 18 **DEX** 8 **CON** 16 **INT** 5 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6
Resist piercing, slashing **Vuln.** thunder
Imm. poison ♦ (cond) charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned
Senses tremorsense 60 ft, passive Perception 11
Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Traits

Resonant Body. Whenever it takes **thunder damage** it is **stunned** until the end of its next turn, and it takes **double damage** from every source while stunned.

Struck Chord. A creature can use an action to strike one of the reef's large spires (DC 13 Athletics). Every Chimestone within 30 ft makes a DC 14 Constitution save or is stunned as above. The striker takes 1d6 thunder damage from standing that close.

Actions

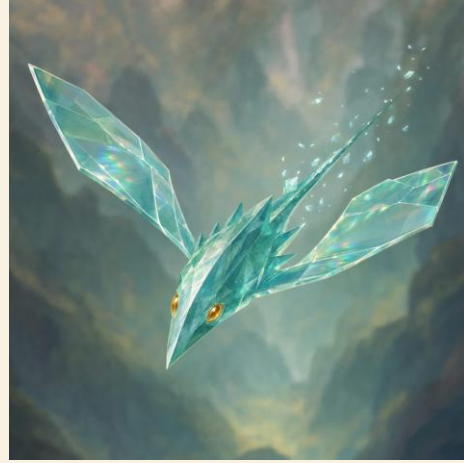
Multiattack. Two Crystal Rams.

Crystal Ram. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 11 (2d6 + 4) bludgeoning damage.

Shard Volley. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 40 ft. *Hit:* 9 (2d8) piercing damage.

SHARDWING

Small elemental, unaligned ♦ CR 1 (200 XP) ♦ 3 in the air above the reef



AC 14 **HP** 22 (5d6 + 5) **Speed** 10 ft, **fly** 50 ft
STR 8 **DEX** 18 **CON** 12 **INT** 4 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6
Vuln. thunder ♦ **Imm.** poison ♦ (cond) poisoned, prone
Senses tremorsense 30 ft, passive Perception 11
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Traits

Glide. It can fly at full speed without provoking opportunity attacks from creatures it starts its turn adjacent to.

Actions

Dive. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 9 (2d6 + 2) slashing damage. If it moved at least 30 ft straight toward the target first, this deals an extra 1d6.

Shard Spit. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 60 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d10 + 2) piercing damage.

Tactics: These are not corrupted. They are the reef's immune system, and the party is loud and warm and came in through a hole. **The lever is thunder.** Any thunder damage stuns a Chimestone until the end of its next turn and doubles all damage against it while it is stunned, which turns a wall with AC 16 into a free kill: Lilly's Thunderwave and Shatter, Ursa's Thunderwave, and Stabby's Nichirin ringing off the crystal all do it, and the Shardwings are vulnerable to thunder too, so one lever answers the whole encounter. The reef itself is the second weapon: an action and a DC 13 Athletics check to strike a big spire sends the note rolling out, and every Chimestone within 30 ft saves or is stunned. The trade keeps it honest, because the striker takes 1d6 thunder from standing that close, and nobody has ever minded. Play the Chimestones as the wall and the Shardwings as the reason nobody gets to stand still: they dive, they spit from sixty feet, and they will not be pinned down. A party that never finds the lever is in a genuinely hard fight, so do not soften it before they have had their chance to be clever. Call the short rest out loud the moment the reef goes quiet: Hit Dice, Stabby's Focus, Ursa's Wild Shape, Lilly's Aether Ward.

ENEMIES, Fight 3: The Glassed Gallery

The Glassed Gallery ♦ Difficulty: The hardest fight before the boss ♦ 1x Glass Weeper + 4x Cinderoll

GLASS WEEPER

Large plant (corrupted guardian-beast), unaligned ♦ CR 6 (2,300 XP) ♦ still trying to do its job



AC 16 (black glass) **HP** 115 (11d10 + 55) **Speed** 20 ft
STR 18 **DEX** 8 **CON** 20 **INT** 4 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 5
Resist bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical weapons

Imm. poison ♦ (cond) charmed, frightened, poisoned, prone
Senses blindsight 60 ft, passive Perception 11
Challenge 6 (2,300 XP)

Traits

Glassbound. It regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn.

Rooted. It cannot move more than 15 ft from the glassed roots it is tending, and it never tries to.

Tend the Roots. A creature can use an action to clear or heal the roots near it: DC 14 Nature or Medicine, or any healing spell cast on the roots rather than a creature. On a success the Weeper loses Glassbound until the end of its next turn and every attack against it has **advantage** until the start of the helper's next turn.

Actions

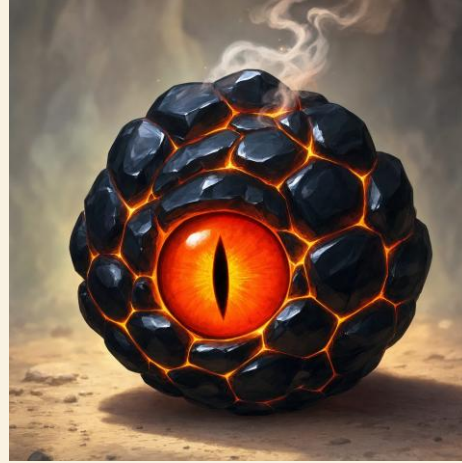
Multiattack. Three Frond Lashes.

Frond Lash. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage.

Keening (Recharge 5-6). 30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution save: 21 (6d6) psychic damage and frightened until the end of its next turn; half damage and no fear on a success.

CINDEROLL

Small elemental (corrupted), unaligned ♦ CR 1/2 (100 XP) ♦ 4 in the gallery, arriving two at a time



AC 15 (glassy coal) **HP** 18 (4d6 + 4) **Speed** 40 ft (rolling)
STR 12 **DEX** 14 **CON** 12 **INT** 3 **WIS** 8 **CHA** 3

Imm. fire, poison ♦ (cond) blinded, charmed, deafened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 60 ft, passive Perception 9

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Traits

Rolling Charge. If it moves at least 20 ft straight toward a target before hitting it, the attack deals an extra 3 (1d6) damage and the target makes a DC 12 Strength save or is knocked prone.

Burst. When it drops to 0 hit points it cracks open: each creature within 10 ft makes a DC 12 Dexterity save or takes 7 (2d6) fire damage.

Actions

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (2d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage plus 3 (1d6) fire damage.

Tactics: This is the big fight of the run before the boss and it should be hard. The Weeper hits for real, it regenerates 10 a round, and the Cinderolls keep rolling in and detonating, two at a time so the pressure never stops but never quite swamps the party. **The lever is the roots.** The Weeper is bound to the glassed roots it is still trying to comb clean, so any hero who spends an action tending them (DC 14 Nature or Medicine, or any healing spell aimed at the roots rather than a creature) strips its regeneration for a round and hands everyone advantage against it. Two or three of those and the fight tips hard. It never ends the encounter: it makes the party feel brilliant while they finish it. This is also Stabby's proving ground, because 10 hit points a round means every wound they open is part closed before they swing again, and only radiant, force, or Cleansing Edge shuts Glassbound off. He is the reason this fight stops going backwards, and everyone at the table should be able to see it. Let the Cinderolls cluster: killing one next to three others is a chain reaction, and the players should be allowed to discover that and enjoy it. When the Weeper falls it shatters, and curled up where its heart would be is a small ordinary creature that has been dead for two years. That is the beat that turns the session from an adventure into a rescue, so let the table sit with it before anyone moves on.

ENEMIES, BOSS: Groudon's Hollow

Groudon's Hollow ♦ Difficulty: Boss, but the spike is the whole fight ♦ 1x Groudon + one Glassling every round

GROUDON, THE CONTINENT-MAKER

Gargantuan elemental (Plane of Earth, Guardian), unaligned ♦ CR 11 (7,200 XP) as run here ♦ he is not the villain, the spike is



AC 18 (mountain plate) **HP** 230 (but see The Spike) **Speed** 40 ft, burrow 40 ft
STR 26 **DEX** 6 **CON** 24 **INT** 8 **WIS** 14 **CHA** 12
Resist all damage from nonmagical weapons
Imm. fire, poison ♦ (cond) most
Senses tremorsense 120 ft, passive Perception 12
Challenge 11 (7,200 XP)

Traits

THE SPIKE (this is the encounter). A shard of black glass is driven into his back at the shoulder. **AC 17, 60 hit points**, immune to all damage except **radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge**. Reaching it requires climbing him, flying, or a ranged attack at disadvantage. **When the spike is destroyed the encounter ends immediately**, whatever Groudon's hit points are. Do not run him to 0. He is not supposed to die.

Unstoppable. He cannot be frightened, charmed, restrained, or knocked prone, and he ignores difficult terrain.

Agony. While the spike is intact, at the start of each of his turns he takes 10 damage and everything within 20 ft makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or takes 10 (3d6) bludgeoning damage from the shockwave.

He Does Not Finish Them. When Groudon reduces a creature to 0 hit points, he immediately moves away from it. He is swatting at pain, not hunting children.

Actions

Continental Step. He moves up to his speed. Every creature on the ground within 30 ft of his path makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or is knocked prone and takes 11 (2d10) bludgeoning damage.

Magma Vent (Recharge 4-6). A 60-ft line, 10 ft wide. DC 17 Dexterity save: 35 (10d6) fire damage, half on a success.

Claw. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +12 to hit, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 24 (3d10 + 8) slashing damage.

Thrash (when the spike takes damage, 1/round, no action). Every creature climbing him makes a DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check or falls, taking 3d6 bludgeoning damage.

GLASSLING

Tiny construct (spawned by the spike), unaligned ♦ CR 1/4 (50 XP) ♦ one new one every round the spike lives



AC 14 **HP** 10 (3d4 + 3) **Speed** 30 ft, climb 30 ft
STR 8 **DEX** 16 **CON** 12 **INT** 1 **WIS** 6 **CHA** 1

Imm. poison, psychic ♦ (cond) blinded, charmed, deafened, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 30 ft, passive Perception 8

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Traits

Spike-Born. The spike creates one Glassling at the start of each of Groudon's turns. When the spike is destroyed, every Glassling collapses into ordinary sand immediately, wherever it is and whatever it was doing.

Shatterburst. At 0 hit points, each creature within 5 ft makes a DC 12 Dexterity save or takes 5 (2d4) slashing damage.

Actions

Glass Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Tactics: Do not let the party win by damage. Groudon has more hit points than they can chew through and hits hard enough to drop a hero in two turns, so a straight brawl is a loss. The win condition is the spike: AC 17, 60 hit points, immune to everything except radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge, reached by climbing him, by flight

(Stabby's Sash, Ursa's Starry Form), or by a called shot at range with disadvantage. Break it and the fight is over on the spot, not whittled down. The Glasslings are the answer to the obvious question, which is why not ignore the spike and whittle Groudon from range: one more of them drops off his back at the start of every one of his turns, so the longer the spike lives the more little glass things are chewing on the party, and the instant the spike goes every one of them collapses into sand at once and the whole board clears in a heartbeat. Play Groudon as a natural disaster with a wounded animal inside it rather than a tactician, alternating Continental Step, Magma Vent, Claw, and Thrash when the spike is struck. Every hero has a role: Stabby climbs a mountain that is trying to shake him off and cuts the corruption out of a god, and this is his moment, so do not let anyone else take it unless his player hands it over; Ursa keeps people standing and can put a summon between Groudon and the climber, and his Mark of Handling lets him feel that the creature is in pain, which is the line that turns the fight into a rescue; Lilly shoots the spike from range, holds the party together with Aether Ward, and Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles is force damage that never misses. If the dice go badly, let a summon pin Groudon or let Flash of Genius rescue the climb check so the last blow is still Stabby's. Mercy rule for the table: if a hero drops, Groudon does not finish them. He is not killed here. He is freed.

ENEMIES: The Road Between

Anywhere on the board ♦ Difficulty: Small pressure ♦ dot encounters only

THUMPAW

Large beast (Plane of Earth), unaligned ♦ CR 3 (700 XP) ♦ random encounters only ♦ 1, and it was there first



AC 14 (mossy hide) **HP** 76 (8d10 + 32) **Speed** 30 ft, burrow 30 ft

STR 20 **DEX** 8 **CON** 18 **INT** 3 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6

Senses tremorsense 60 ft, passive Perception 13

Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Traits

Not Actually Angry. It does not attack until attacked, and it never pursues. It is in the way and it was there first.

Immovable. It has advantage on saves and checks against being moved, and it cannot be knocked prone.

Actions

Multiattack. Two Shovel Slams.

Shovel Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +8 to hit, reach 10 ft. *Hit:* 14 (2d8 + 5) bludgeoning damage.

GLEAMOTH SWARM

Medium swarm of Tiny beasts, unaligned ♦ CR 1 (200 XP) ♦ random encounters only ♦ 3 swarms, and they want the warmest thing in the tunnel



AC 12 **HP** 26 (4d8 + 8) **Speed** 5 ft, fly 40 ft (hover)

STR 4 **DEX** 14 **CON** 14 **INT** 1 **WIS** 10 **CHA** 4

Resist bludgeoning, piercing, slashing **Vuln.** fire, thunder

Imm. (cond) charmed, frightened, grappled, prone, restrained, stunned

Senses blindsight 20 ft, passive Perception 10

Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Traits

Drawn to Warmth. It always moves toward the warmest or brightest thing it can sense, which is the Essence Sphere. If Lilly is carrying it, the swarm goes for her every turn.

Swarm. It can occupy another creature's space and move through any opening large enough for a single moth.

Actions

Smother. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 0 ft, one creature in its space. *Hit:* 10 (4d4) piercing damage, or 5 (2d4) if the swarm is at half its hit points or fewer, and the target is **blinded** until the end of its next turn.

Tactics: These two never appear at a scripted fight. They are what a garnet dot means, and they are the only creatures the party meets purely by luck, which is what keeps a dot roll feeling different from a story beat instead of feeling like filler. Keep them small: a little pressure, a little resource, and no more. Do not let a dot roll swell into a fifth big fight, because the four scripted encounters are the session. Thumpaw is a straight brawl with no gimmick and no puzzle, 76 hit points and two big slams a turn, for the moments when the table simply wants to hit something large until it stops; it never pursues and it never finishes a downed hero, because it is grumpy, not evil.

(If the players think of befriending it instead, a DC 15 Animal Handling check with advantage from Ursa's Mark moves it aside. Do not offer this. Let them find it.) The Gleamoths are not corrupted either, just hungry for heat: they blind and smother rather than deal much damage, fire and thunder scatter them fast, and anything that hits an area is worth double. The cost is the Sphere, which pulls them hardest, so the swarm sits on Lilly the whole fight and the rest of the party has to come to her.

◆ **LORE OF ELARIA** ◆ **The Two Lists**

The Circle's bestiary of the Darkening keeps two lists. The frightening one is long: the twisted, the glassed, the re-blooming, every creature the leaking dark has worn like a glove. The kind one is longer, and it is the same list, written again after somebody set them free. Corruption, the sky-readers say, is a thing that happens to a creature, never a thing that it is. Strike to free, not to punish, and a world will hand you back more friends than enemies.
